A DOCTORAL DISSERTATION

Thinking Like a Desert

Prescience, Pharmakon, and the Chronoecology of Sovereignty in Frank Herbert's Dune



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ABSTRACT

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This dissertation argues that Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), read together with the five sequels Herbert conceived as the unfolding of its latent argument, is neither primarily an ecological parable, a monomythic romance, nor a cautionary tale about charismatic leadership, though it is demonstrably all three, but a speculative treatise on the ecology of time. Herbert's universe is organized by a set of homologous economies (of water, spice, genes, ancestral memory, charisma, and prophecy), each governed by a single pharmacological law, according to which the substance that sustains life is the substance that destroys it, and by a single immunitary mechanism, according to which a community preserves itself by incorporating a measured dose of its own negation. Prescience, the series' master figure, is the extractive industry of this economy: it converts open possibility into determinate certainty and thereby depletes the generative capacity of the future itself. Under the name *chronoecology*, the dissertation develops four concepts to describe this process: *prescient extraction*, the conversion of futurity into commodity and command; *temporal desertification*, the exhaustion of a future overgrazed by prediction; *immunitary sovereignty*, the form of rule that protects life by administering its negation; and *temporal rewilding*, the deliberate reintroduction of unpredictability into a domesticated future. The argument is anchored throughout in the novel's own apparatus (the forty-eight epigraphs from Irulan's histories, the four appendices, and the glossary), whose vocabulary of "infectious superstitions," susceptibility, and parasitism supplies the textual basis for the immunitary reading.

Part I reconstructs the genealogy from which Herbert assembled these ideas: Alfred Korzybski's general semantics and its definition of the human as a time-binding organism; the analytical psychology of C. G. Jung and the existentialism of Karl Jaspers and Martin Heidegger, transmitted to Herbert through the psychotherapists Ralph and Irene Slattery; Zen and Stoic disciplines of attention; Ibn Khaldun's cyclical sociology of desert and city, the desert insurgencies narrated by T. E. Lawrence and Lesley Blanch, and Max Weber's theory of charismatic authority and its routinization; the ecology of Paul Sears, Aldo Leopold, and Rachel Carson; Samuel Butler's evolutionary account of machines and Lewis Mumford's megamachine; and the eugenic imagination extending from Plato's *Republic* through Francis Galton to Friedrich Nietzsche. Part II situates *Dune* morphologically within speculative and philosophical fiction, against Isaac Asimov's psychohistory, Ursula K. Le Guin's Foretellers and temporal physics, Jorge Luis Borges's labyrinths of time and memory, Ted Chiang's teleological consciousness, Liu Cixin's Wallfacers, Fyodor Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, Philip K. Dick's empathy test, Gene Wolfe's compound Autarch, Octavia E. Butler's millennial breeder, Kim

Stanley Robinson's terraforming ethics, and Iain M. Banks's governing Minds. Part III advances the original thesis. Reading the three-and-a-half-millennium tyranny of Leto II through Leopold's parable of thinking like a mountain, Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan*, Roberto Esposito's paradigm of immunization, and Jacques Derrida's pharmakon, it argues that the Golden Path constitutes the first fully articulated literary instance of temporal rewilding: a sacrificial sovereign who becomes the keystone predator of the human future, who rules in order to immunize the species against rule by foresight, and whose reign culminates in the breeding of a humanity invisible to prediction. The dissertation concludes that Herbert's lifelong critique of the hero is, at its foundation, an ecological ethics of futurity, and that its central demand, the right to remain unforeseen, acquires a new and pressing salience in an epoch in which the capacity to forecast human behavior has become a dominant modality of power.

Contents

Abstract 2

INTRODUCTION The Herbertian Paradox and the Ecology of Time 5

PART I

Genealogies: The Originators 9

1 Korzybski's Desert 10
General Semantics, Time-Binding, and the Disciplines of Perception

2 The Ordeal of the Human 14
Jung, Jaspers, Heidegger, Zen, and the Stoa

3 The Sands of Empire 19
Ibn Khaldun, Lawrence, Blanch, and the Political Theology of Charisma

4 The Planetologist's Ethic 24
Florence, Sears, Leopold, and the Petro-Ecology of Arrakis

5 Machines and Bloodlines 28
Butler, Mumford, Plato, Galton, Nietzsche

PART II

Comparative Morphologies 32

6 The Calculus of the Future 33
Asimov, Le Guin, Borges, Chiang, Liu, Vonnegut

7 Messiahs and Their Discontents 37
Dostoevsky, Heinlein, Clarke, Dick, Wolfe, Octavia E. Butler, Tolkien, Stapledon

8 Planets and Minds 41
Le Guin, Robinson, Lem, Miller, Banks, Simmons, and Herbert Against Herbert

PART III

Thinking Like a Desert: Toward a Chronoecology of Sovereignty 45

9 The Commons of the Future 46
Prescient Extraction and Temporal Desertification

10 Immunitas 51
The Immunitary Architectures of the Imperium

11 The Keystone Sovereign 55
Leto II, Leviathan, and the Rewilding of Time

CONCLUSION *Dune* After Prediction 60

Works Cited 63

Keywords 68

INTRODUCTION

The Herbertian Paradox and the Ecology of Time

I.1
The Herbertian Paradox

Few works of twentieth-century fiction have been so durably misread by so many of their admirers as *Dune*. Serialized in John W. Campbell's *Analog* as "Dune World" (1963–64) and "The Prophet of Dune" (1965), declined by some twenty publishers before Chilton Books, a Philadelphia house better known for automotive repair manuals, issued it in 1965, and honored with the inaugural Nebula Award and a share of the 1966 Hugo, the novel entered the culture as the epic of a dispossessed young aristocrat who masters a lethal desert, unites its warrior people, and dethrones an emperor. That is its plot; it is not its argument. Herbert insisted, across essays and interviews, that the series was engineered as a demonstration of the dangers of charismatic leadership: that superheroes are disastrous for the humans who follow them, that even an infallible hero sets in motion processes that devolve upon fallible successors, and that the charismatic leader ought to arrive bearing a warning label (Herbert 1980). He named John F. Kennedy among the leaders he regarded as dangerous precisely because charisma suspended critical scrutiny. When he delivered *Dune Messiah*, in which the triumphant Muad'Dib presides over a jihad waged by Fremen legions in his name (by Paul's own conservative tally, which he sets beside Hitler's murders, sixty-one billion dead and ninety planets sterilized), Campbell declined it, reportedly unwilling to publish the unmaking of a hero; it appeared instead in *Galaxy* (1969).

The difficulty, which this dissertation terms the *Herbertian paradox*, is that Herbert elected to indict the hero by perfecting the heroic narrative. *Dune* reproduces with uncanny fidelity the morphology that Joseph Campbell abstracted in *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949): the departure from the paternal world of Caladan, the threshold ordeal of the gom jabbar, the death of the father, the descent into the underworld of desert and sietch, the supernatural aid of the Water of Life, the apotheosis. It does so with such libidinal satisfaction that, for most readers, the critique arrives too late, in sequels many never open. Yet the critique is already inscribed in the architecture of the first novel. It is inscribed in the chapter epigraphs drawn from the Princess Irulan's hagiographies, which deliver Paul to the reader only through the apparatus of his own

cult. All forty-eight chapters open with an excerpt from Irulan's corpus, a library of more than a dozen titles that runs from the *Manual of Muad'Dib* and *Arrakis Awakening* through family commentaries, collected sayings, and a dictionary to *A Child's History of Muad'Dib*; and the epigraph that opens the novel, after warning that beginnings demand the most delicate care that the balances be correct, instructs the reader to "place him in his time" (Book I). The critique is inscribed, too, in the appendices and the closing "Terminology of the Imperium," which define the Missionaria Protectiva as the arm of the Sisterhood charged with "sowing infectious superstitions" on primitive worlds and document its centuries-long seeding of messianic legend among the Fremen, so that Paul's "fulfillment" of prophecy is exposed as the activation of a planted myth; and in Paul's own visions, from his first spice-saturated awakening in the stilltent, of a jihad he cannot prevent and to which each of his victories contributes. *Dune* is a novel whose paratexts instruct the reader not to believe its text.

The critical reception has partitioned the novel among four interpretive estates. The ecological estate, inaugurated by the counterculture that adopted *Dune* as a planetary scripture, reads it as the founding novel of ecological science fiction. The mythopoetic estate, following Campbell and Jung, reads Paul as archetype. The political estate (O'Reilly 1981; Touponce 1988; Kennedy 2022) foregrounds the critique of charisma, feudalism, and empire. The postcolonial estate, energized by Will Collins's documentation (2017) of Herbert's borrowings from Lesley Blanch's *The Sabres of Paradise* and by the critique of Orientalism after Edward Said (1978), interrogates the novel's appropriation of Islamic, Arabic, and Caucasian materials and its proximity to the white-savior topos. Each estate is partially correct; none can account for the others. What they share is a tacit decision to treat time as the medium of Herbert's narrative rather than as its object.

1.2 The Argument

This dissertation contends that the object of *Dune* is time: time understood not as the neutral dimension in which events are arrayed, but as an ecology, a living, finite, and depletable system whose capacity to generate novelty can be cultivated, conserved, exhausted, or restored. I call the study of this system *chronoecology*, a term employed here in a sense distinct from its occasional use in chronobiology. The argument is advanced through four propositions.

The first proposition is that Herbert's universe is structured by homologous economies (water on Arrakis, melange across the Imperium, genetic lines in the Bene Gesserit program, ancestral memory in the Reverend Mothers, charisma in the Fremen jihad, prophecy in the Spacing Guild and the house of Atreides), and that every one of them obeys the same pharmacological law: what sustains also kills. Melange extends life and induces an addiction that the novel's glossary grades from mild to severe, binding Jessica and Paul to Arrakis beyond any power of the Sisterhood to free them; the Water of Life is a poison the adept must transmute within her own metabolism; the gom jabbar defines the human through its capacity to hold pain and lethal

threat in awareness; religion, sown as prophylaxis, becomes the vector of catastrophe. Jacques Derrida's reading of the Platonic *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison and undecidably both, names this logic more exactly than any category in the existing criticism.

The second proposition is that these economies are administered by immunitary institutions in Roberto Esposito's sense: apparatuses that protect life by inoculating it with a controlled dose of its own negation. The stillsuit, the Litany Against Fear, the Butlerian prohibition of thinking machines, the Great Convention's interdiction of atomics, the Missionaria Protectiva's prophylactic myths, and the Reverend Mother's metabolic conversion of poison are immunitary technologies; and the catastrophes of the series are, without exception, autoimmune. The breeding program yields an uncontrollable Kwisatz Haderach; the prophylactic myth becomes the vehicle of jihad; the ecological dream of a verdant Arrakis threatens the sandworm on which the spice, and therefore the Imperium, depends; Alia's ancestral memory consumes the self it was meant to enlarge.

The third proposition is that prescience is the master instance of this logic and the extractive industry of time. Herbert explicitly models Paul's foresight on Heisenbergian indeterminacy. In the cave, moments before his duel with Jamis, Paul grasps that prescience is an illumination containing the limits of what it reveals, at once a source of accuracy and of "meaningful error," because the energy spent in seeing the future changes what is seen (Book II). To foresee is to fix; to fix is to deplete the reservoir of unrealized possibility from which a species draws its capacity to adapt. A civilization that predicts too well, such as the Imperium of ten feudal millennia, navigated by Guild Steersmen who perceive only the safe path, suffers what I term *temporal desertification*. Here Korzybski's definition of humanity as the time-binding class of life, which Herbert absorbed through general semantics, is pressed to its terminus: Other Memory binds the totality of the past into the living mind, prescience binds the future, and time-binding becomes time-bondage.

The fourth proposition is that Leto II's Golden Path, the thirty-five-century tyranny of a man who becomes a sandworm, is the first fully articulated literary instance of *temporal rewilding*: the deliberate and sacrificial reintroduction of unpredictability into a domesticated future. Read through Aldo Leopold's parable of the wolf whose extermination ruins the mountain, Leto is the keystone predator of human time. Read through Hobbes, he is a Leviathan who rules in order to render all future Leviathans impossible. Read through Dostoevsky, he is a Grand Inquisitor who enslaves humanity in order to make enslavement intolerable to it. Read through Esposito, his reign is an inoculation of the species, administered at the dose of thirty-five centuries, against the messianic itself. Its culmination is the Scattering and the breeding, in Siona Atreides, of a humanity invisible to prescience: a humanity returned to the condition of a wild future. The dissertation's name for the ethical and epistemic disposition this entails is *thinking like a desert*, the evaluation of any regime of knowledge, power, or care not by the predictability it secures but by the capacity for surprise it conserves.

1.3

Corpus, Method, Conventions

The primary corpus is *Dune*. Because Herbert conceived *Dune Messiah* (1969) and *Children of Dune* (1976) as the completion of a single argument, and *God Emperor of Dune* (1981), *Heretics of Dune* (1984), and *Chapterhouse: Dune* (1985) as its extrapolation, those five novels constitute the secondary corpus. The prequels and continuations composed after Herbert's death in 1986 by Brian Herbert and Kevin J. Anderson are excluded from the reconstruction of Herbert's thought and are considered in the Conclusion only as a phenomenon of reception. Herbert's nonfiction, including "Dune Genesis" (1980), "Men on Other Planets" (1976), and the Earth Day anthology *New World or No World* (1970), together with his authorized biography (B. Herbert 2003), is read as testimony, not as the arbiter of meaning.

The method combines three procedures. *Source genealogy* reconstructs the documented and probable provenance of Herbert's ideas, distinguishing attested influence (Korzybski; Jung; Blanch; Ibn Khaldun, whose universal history lends its title to the Fremen *Kitab al-Ibar*) from structural convergence (Weber, Hobbes, Esposito). *Comparative morphology* situates *Dune* within the field of speculative and philosophical fiction not as a matter of influence but of shared problems and divergent solutions. *Conceptual synthesis* constructs the chronoecological framework from the materials the first two procedures assemble. References to the novels are given by their internal divisions (Book I "Dune," Book II "Muad'Dib," Book III "The Prophet," and the Appendices) rather than by the pagination of any edition. Quotation is held to a minimum: brief phrases from *Dune* are quoted only where their exact wording carries the argument, and the novel's glossary, the "Terminology of the Imperium," is cited as Terminology.

1.4

Plan of the Dissertation

Part I (Chapters 1–5) reconstructs the originators: general semantics and the time-binding animal (Chapter 1); depth psychology, existentialism, Zen, and Stoicism as disciplines of ordeal (Chapter 2); the political theology of desert, empire, and charisma (Chapter 3); the ecological sciences and the petro-politics of the 1950s and 1960s (Chapter 4); and the twin genealogies of machine and bloodline (Chapter 5). Part II (Chapters 6–8) conducts the comparative morphology across three problematics: prediction (Chapter 6), messianism (Chapter 7), and the relation of planets to minds (Chapter 8). Part III (Chapters 9–11) constructs the chronoecological thesis: the future as a commons subject to prescient extraction and temporal desertification (Chapter 9); the immunitary and autoimmune architectures of the Imperium (Chapter 10); and Leto II as the keystone sovereign of a rewilded time (Chapter 11). The Conclusion assesses the framework's reach beyond Herbert, to the governance of predictive technologies and to the environmental humanities.

I

PART I

Genealogies

The Originators

Herbert was an autodidact of formidable range: a newspaperman, photographer, political speechwriter, and sometime student at the University of Washington who never took a degree. His reading was voracious, eclectic, and conducted largely outside the academy. The genealogical task is therefore not to locate a single master source but to observe the pattern by which heterogeneous materials were selected and bent. The thesis of Part I is that each of Herbert's sources was recruited for its bearing on a single problem: how a finite organism, embedded in a finite environment, can know, bind, and use time without being consumed by it.

CHAPTER 1

Korzybski's Desert

General Semantics, Time-Binding, and the Disciplines of Perception

1.1 The Non-Aristotelian Imperium

Alfred Korzybski's *Science and Sanity* (1933) proposed a "non-Aristotelian" system intended to reform the human nervous system's habitual relation to language. Its axioms are by now proverbial: the map is not the territory; the word is not the thing; no map represents all of its territory; every map is self-reflexive, a map of the mapper as much as of the mapped. From these axioms Korzybski derived a pedagogy ("consciousness of abstracting," the deliberate delay of the "semantic reaction," the extensional habit of attending to particulars before categories) that S. I. Hayakawa popularized for a mass readership in *Language in Action* (1941) and that entered genre science fiction through A. E. van Vogt's *The World of Null-A* (serialized 1945; book 1948), whose Gilbert Gosseyn is a Korzybskian superman, and through the general-semantic enthusiasms of the Campbell circle into which Herbert would sell *Dune*.

Dune's training regimes are general-semantic pedagogies rendered as martial and religious disciplines. The Bene Gesserit adept learns to observe without premature naming, to register the minute particulars of musculature and intonation before assigning them meaning, and to treat her own perceptions as abstractions subject to revision. The Mentat, a human computer bred and trained to fill the cognitive niche vacated by the Butlerian Jihad, operates by the suspension of conclusion; the First Law of Mentat, which Paul repeats to Thufir Hawat early in Book I, holds that a process cannot be understood by halting it, and that understanding must move with the process and become one with its flow. Paul had first quoted it as a riposte. The Reverend Mother had told him that the mystery of life is not a problem to solve but a reality to experience, and the boy answered her mysticism with method (Book I). The exchange stages in miniature the two non-prescient epistemologies between which Paul begins, the Sisterhood's mystery and the Mentat's process; prescience will betray both. This is Korzybski crossed with the process philosophy of Alfred North Whitehead (*Process and Reality*, 1929), on whose critique of the "fallacy of misplaced concreteness" Korzybski himself drew. The Mentat is an anti-essentialist cognitive instrument, trained to resist the "is of identity" that would freeze a moving system into a thing.

1.2

The Catastrophe of the Perfect Map

The fall of House Atreides is, in this light, a Korzybskian tragedy constituted by two cartographic errors. The first is Thufir Hawat's. The Atreides Master of Assassins, a Mentat of impeccable logic, is fed fabricated evidence that the traitor is the Lady Jessica, and his computation, flawless upon its data, converges on falsehood. The perfect map of a counterfeit territory is more dangerous than a crude map of a real one, because its internal consistency forecloses doubt. The second error is institutional. The Suk Imperial Conditioning, believed to render physicians constitutionally incapable of betraying a patient, is taken as an unbreakable property of Dr. Wellington Yueh, when it is only a map of Yueh, and the Baron rewrites it by holding Yueh's wife, Wanna, captive under torture in Piter's pain amplifiers, a pressure the conditioning had never been mapped against. The lever is epistemic as much as physical. Yueh cannot know whether Wanna is dead or still suffering, and he betrays the Duke to buy the certainty that she can no longer be hurt; only at the handover does he read in the Baron's manner that she has been dead all along, and the Baron has Piter de Vries kill him (Book I). Even the biographical epigraph that introduces Yueh marks the year of Wanna's death with a question mark. Duke Leto dies of the confusion between the conditioning and the man. The Baron, for his part, is a Korzybskian virtuoso in the negative: his signature strategy, the plan within the plan within the plan, is the art of authoring an adversary's map, of constructing the territory the enemy will believe he inhabits. That the Baron's own Mentat, Piter de Vries, is a "twisted" Mentat, deliberately corrupted, marks the novel's awareness that an instrument of abstraction can be weaponized against the very sanity it was designed to secure. The deepest cartographic error, however, is imperial. The Fremen, the novel notes in its opening pages, appear on no census of the Imperial Regate (Book I): the people who will decide the planet's fate are missing from the Imperium's map of it, and the Sardaukar will learn the scale of that omission at Arrakeen.

1.3

Time-Binding

The Korzybskian idea most consequential for Herbert, and for this dissertation, is older than general semantics proper. In *Manhood of Humanity* (1921), Korzybski classified life by its characteristic mode of "binding." Plants are chemistry-binders, converting solar energy into organic matter; animals are space-binders, capable of locomotion; humans are time-binders, the only class of life able to accumulate the experience of past generations and transmit it to future ones, so that each generation begins where its predecessors ended. Time-binding was, for Korzybski, both the definition of the human and the engine of a progress he imagined as exponential.

Herbert literalizes time-binding and then interrogates it. Bene Gesserit Other Memory, accessed through the spice agony, binds the entire female line of an adept's ancestry into her living consciousness: the archive is no longer external, in books, institutions, or traditions, but somatic.

The Kwisatz Haderach, goal of the order's ninety-generation breeding program, is designed to bind both lines of descent, male and female, including the region of the ancestral psyche the Reverend Mothers cannot bear to look upon; and because his access to time is not confined to the past, he binds the future as well. In Paul, Korzybski's definition of the human is realized without remainder, and the realization is catastrophic. A being who binds all time is bound by it. Alia, pre-born, flooded with ancestral memory in the womb when Jessica drank the Water of Life, becomes the first casualty of total time-binding: what the Bene Gesserit call Abomination is the possession of the living by the archive, and its emblem is the Baron Harkonnen, Alia's grandfather, speaking from within her. Leto II, heir to the same plenitude, will spend thirty-five centuries attempting to reverse its consequences. This dissertation names the pathology *time-bondage*: the condition in which the capacity that defines the human, the carrying of time, becomes the mechanism of its enslavement.

1.4

Semantic Power: The Voice, the Name, the Engineered Word

If Korzybski taught that semantic reactions are neurological events, Herbert concluded that whoever governs the semantic reaction governs the organism. The Bene Gesserit Voice, a modulation of tone, pitch, and register that compels obedience in the untrained listener, literalizes what J. L. Austin, in lectures delivered at Harvard in 1955 and published as *How to Do Things with Words* (1962), called the performative utterance: speech that does not describe an act but performs it. The Voice is perlocutionary force stripped of its social mediation and applied directly to the nervous system. Its countermeasure is, accordingly, a semantic discipline: the trained hearer perceives the Voice as a pattern of sound, abstracts it, and declines to react. The glossary carries the logic to its limit in the entry on *uroshnor*, one of several sounds "empty of general meaning" that the Bene Gesserit implant in selected victims for purposes of control (Terminology): a performative stripped of every descriptive residue, force without sense. At the climax, when Gurney Halleck warns that Feyd-Rautha has probably been so prepared, Paul declines the advantage (Book III); the Kwisatz Haderach will not win his decisive duel by semantic remote control. He does not, however, renounce the Voice. Facing Mohiam at the climax, he reminds her that he remembers her gom jabbar as she now remembers his, and that he can kill her with a word, while the watching Fremen hear a legend fulfilled (Book III).

Herbert's linguistic world elaborates the hypothesis associated with Benjamin Lee Whorf (*Language, Thought, and Reality*, 1956) that the structure of a language conditions the structure of the thought it carries. House Atreides maintains a private battle language and a language of hand signs; the Fremen speak Chakobsa, a name Herbert took from Blanch's account of a secret Caucasian hunting language; and the naming rites of the sietch are acts of semantic destiny-making. When Paul chooses the name Muad'Dib, the desert kangaroo mouse whose figure the Fremen read in the shadows of the second moon, he enters not merely a community but a sign-sys-

tem in which the landscape is already a text and his name already a prophecy. The most ambitious semantic engineering in the series, however, belongs to the Missionaria Protectiva, whose agents seed legends, superstitions, and prophecies across primitive worlds, phrased so as to be exploitable by any Bene Gesserit who later finds herself in danger among them. This is language engineering at the scale of civilizations, and its nearest literary antecedent is *The Languages of Pao* (1958) by Herbert's friend Jack Vance, in which an oligarchy redesigns a planet's culture by inventing distinct languages for warrior, merchant, and technician castes. What Vance imagined as social science, Herbert imagined as theology. The Missionaria Protectiva shapes not only how a people speaks but what it hopes for.

1.5

Conclusion: The Desert of the Real

Korzybski supplied Herbert with three instruments: a definition of the human as the time-binding animal, a theory of power as the government of semantic reaction, and a pedagogy of sanity as the disciplined delay between stimulus and response. Herbert's innovation was to discover the shadow of each. Time-binding culminates in time-bondage; semantic power culminates in a manufactured messiah; and the disciplined delay, as Chapter 2 will show, becomes the very definition of the human that the Bene Gesserit test with a poisoned needle. Arrakis, where every drop of water is accounted for and every footprint read, is the Korzybskian planet par excellence, the desert of the real (to borrow Jean Baudrillard's later phrase) on which no false map survives contact with the territory. It is therefore the place where, paradoxically, the most consequential false map of all, the planted Fremen prophecy of the Lisan al-Gaib, proves most potent.

CHAPTER 2

The Ordeal of the Human

Jung, Jaspers, Heidegger, Zen, and the Stoa

2.1 The Slattery Seminar

Herbert's biographer records that in the years after the Second World War the psychotherapists Ralph and Irene Slattery introduced Herbert to the works of Freud, Jung, Jaspers, and Heidegger, and to Zen Buddhism (B. Herbert 2003). The durability of this informal seminar is legible throughout the fiction. Herbert's first novel, *The Dragon in the Sea* (1956), is a submarine thriller whose protagonist is a psychologist assigned to diagnose a crew under pressure; the consciousness-altering substance at the center of *The Santaroga Barrier* (1968) is named, without irony, Jaspers; and *Dune*'s three great ordeals, the gom jabbar, the spice agony, and the Water of Life, are staged as clinical-existential experiments upon the boundary of the self.

2.2 The Genealogical Unconscious

Jung's collective unconscious, the transpersonal stratum of the psyche populated by archetypes understood as inherited dispositions to form certain images (*The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*, CW 9i), is the most frequently cited antecedent of Other Memory. The comparison requires correction. Jung's collective unconscious is impersonal: it contains forms, not persons, and its contents become personal only when individual experience fills them. Herbert's Other Memory is personal through and through. The Reverend Mother does not encounter the Great Mother but her own grandmothers, individually, each with her history, appetites, and agenda. Herbert converts the archetypal unconscious into what may be called a *genealogical unconscious*, an inherited archive of actual lives, and thereby shifts the problem from the interpretation of symbols to the governance of a population. The Reverend Mother's inner life is a parliament of ancestors; Alia's is a parliament overthrown by a coup.

The archetypes nonetheless structure the first novel with diagrammatic clarity. The Bene Gesserit are the Great Mother in her dual aspect, nurturing and devouring: the order that trains Jessica is the order that would have killed Paul with the gom jabbar. The Harkonnens are the Shadow, and the novel's most consequential revelation is that the Shadow is in the blood. Jessica is the

Baron's natural daughter, so that the gross, appetitive, cunning grandfather is a constituent of Paul's own lineage. The novel closes this circuit with emblematic precision. Alia, captured and brought before the Emperor, kills the Baron with a poisoned needle, apologizing to her grandfather as she tells him he has met "the Atreides gom jabbar" (Book III). The instrument that tests for humanity becomes the instrument with which the line destroys its own Shadow. The Kwisatz Haderach is the Self in Jung's late sense, the *coniunctio oppositorum* elaborated in *Mysterium Coniunctionis* (1955–56) through the symbolism of alchemy: the union of masculine and feminine, conscious and unconscious. Paul's distinctive capacity to look into both the male and the female ancestral spaces, including the region the Reverend Mothers dare not see, is the alchemical marriage made into a psychic faculty. Paul gives the doctrine its formula after the Water of Life: each person carries an ancient force that takes and an ancient force that gives; a man can face the first but scarcely the second, a woman the reverse; and he stands at the fulcrum, unable to give without taking or to take without giving (Book III). The Water of Life ordeal, with its deathlike coma of three weeks and its rebirth into total vision, follows the alchemical sequence from *nigredo* to *rubedo* and the initiatory pattern of death and resurrection that Mircea Eliade traced across cultures (*Birth and Rebirth*, 1958).

2.3

Inflation and the Mana-Personality

Jung's most precise contribution to Herbert's critique of the hero is not the archetype but the danger the archetype poses to the ego that assimilates it. In *Two Essays on Analytical Psychology* (1928; revised 1943), Jung warned that the individual who integrates the contents of the collective unconscious risks identifying with the archetype of the *mana-personality* (the hero, the sage, the magician, the savior) and suffering an "inflation" in which the ego mistakes itself for the transpersonal power it has encountered. The inflated ego becomes at once grandiose and a magnet for the projections of others. This is Herbert's diagnosis of Paul with clinical exactitude. The tragedy of Muad'Dib is not that he is a fraud, for his powers are real, but that he *is* the archetype, and the archetype devours the man. Charismatic leadership, in Herbert's account, is collective inflation: a mass projection of the Self onto a person, which that person can neither refuse nor survive. *Dune Messiah* presents a man who knows that he is inflated, knows that the projection is destroying both himself and his followers, and cannot deflate, because his own foresight shows him that every attempt to step aside yields a worse outcome. Herbert's "warning label" is a Jungian clinical caution transposed to politics.

2.4

The Gom Jabbar as Limit Situation

Karl Jaspers's concept of the *Grenzsituation*, the limit or boundary situation developed in *Psychologie der Weltanschauungen* (1919) and systematized in the second volume of *Philosophie* (1932),

designates the situations that cannot be surmounted or altered but only endured: death, suffering, struggle, guilt. In confronting them, Jaspers argued, the individual is thrown back upon *Existenz*, the irreducible selfhood that no objective description captures. The gom jabbar test is an artificial limit situation constructed with laboratory precision; the glossary names it, with clinical exactness, the "death-alternative test of human awareness" (Terminology). Paul places his hand in a box that induces pain indistinguishable from burning; a needle tipped with lethal poison rests against his neck; withdrawal of the hand means death. The test does not measure intelligence, strength, or virtue. It measures whether the subject can remain within the limit situation in awareness rather than flee it by reflex. The Reverend Mother's gloss, that an animal caught in a trap will gnaw off its own leg to escape whereas a human will endure the pain, feign death, and wait for the chance to kill the trapper, defines the human not by reason or language but by the capacity to interpose duration between stimulus and response.

The definition deserves emphasis, because it is the hinge between Herbert's psychology and the chronoecological thesis. The gom jabbar defines the human temporally, as the organism capable of waiting. Its philosophical lineage is long: Aristotle's *enkrateia*, the continence that holds appetite in check (*Nicomachean Ethics* VII); Kant's autonomy, the will's legislation against inclination; Freud's account, in "Formulations on the Two Principles of Mental Functioning" (1911), of thought as an experimental action that defers motor discharge. Herbert's formulation is distinctive in rendering the interval itself, rather than the faculty that occupies it, as the criterion of humanity. The Fremen refine the definition. On Arrakis survival is a matter of patience: of walking without rhythm so as not to summon the worm, of waiting out the heat in the stilltent, of accumulating water drop by drop across generations toward a goal no living Fremen will see. The human is the animal that can wait; the desert is the school of waiting; and the deepest threat in the series, as Part III will argue, is a regime of foresight that abolishes the interval by delivering the future before it arrives.

2.5
Being-toward-Death and the Foreclosure of Possibility

Heidegger's *Sein und Zeit* (1927) defines Dasein, the being for whom its own being is at issue, as essentially temporal: constituted by thrownness (*Geworfenheit*) into a world not of its choosing, by projection (*Entwurf*) toward possibilities, and by being-toward-death, the anticipation of the one possibility that is absolutely one's own. Authenticity is anticipatory resoluteness, a running-ahead (*Vorlaufen*) into death that frees Dasein from its absorption in the anonymous "they" (*das Man*). And Heidegger subordinates actuality to possibility: Dasein is its possibilities before it is any of its actualities, and possibility, in his famous ranking, stands higher than actuality.

Paul's prescience is a parodic literalization of Heideggerian anticipation, and the parody is instructive. Paul runs ahead, not into his death as a possibility, but into a vast branching field of actualities-in-advance. What Heidegger's *Vorlaufen* discloses as open, Paul's foresight discloses as

already decided. His "terrible purpose" is thrownness raised to the second power: he is thrown not merely into a world but into a future. The phrase enters the novel at the close of the gom jabbar test, when Paul feels himself "infected with terrible purpose" without yet knowing what the purpose is (Book I); in the stilltent at the end of Book I it returns as the race consciousness that moves every party alike. His relation to the Fremen masses who worship him inverts Heidegger's authenticity, for the "they" do not absorb him; he absorbs them, becoming the screen onto which the anonymous collective projects its destiny. Prescience, in Heideggerian terms, is the conversion of possibility into actuality before the fact, the abolition of the very mode of being that makes Dasein what it is. This is the first, existential formulation of what Part III will call prescient extraction.

2.6

Zensunni and the Stoa: Disciplines of Attention

The Fremen descend from Zensunni wanderers, and the portmanteau is precise: the meditative discipline of Zen joined to the legal and scriptural tradition of Sunni Islam. The practice that most fully expresses this synthesis is the Litany Against Fear, the Bene Gesserit formula Paul recites beneath the gom jabbar. Without reproducing it, its structure may be described: fear is named as the destroyer of mind; the speaker resolves to face it, to permit it to pass over and through the self, and to turn the inner eye upon its path; when it has gone, nothing remains but the one who observed it. Functionally, this is a noting practice of the kind cultivated in Buddhist *vipassana* and in the Zen discipline of non-attachment, transmitted to mid-century American readers by Alan Watts's *The Way of Zen* (1957). It is equally a Stoic exercise. Seneca, in *De Ira*, distinguishes the involuntary "first movements" of emotion, which even the sage suffers, from the assent that converts them into passions; Epictetus's *Enchiridion* opens with the distinction between what is up to us and what is not. The Litany does not suppress fear. It withholds assent from it.

Pierre Hadot's reconstruction of ancient philosophy as a repertoire of *exercices spirituels* (1981), and Michel Foucault's late work on "technologies of the self" (1988), supply the appropriate frame for the Bene Gesserit as an institution. The Sisterhood is a philosophical school in the ancient sense, an order dedicated to the transformation of its members through *askesis*: prana-bindu training in the minute control of nerve and muscle, mnemonic disciplines, truthsaying, the Voice. Its adepts are made, not born. Herbert's anthropology is therefore constructivist: the human, like the desert, is a system produced by disciplined practices sustained over time. Peter Sloterdijk's later term for such practices, *anthropotechnics* (*Du mußt dein Leben ändern*, 2009), names what the Bene Gesserit already are.

2.7

Problem and Mystery

One aphorism in *Dune* distinguishes the mystery of life from a problem awaiting solution: life, it holds, is a reality to be experienced rather than a puzzle to be solved. Paul attributes it to the Reverend Mother and answers it, in the same breath, with the First Law of Mentat (Book I). The formulation reproduces almost exactly Gabriel Marcel's distinction, in *Être et avoir* (1935), between a *problème*, which stands before the inquirer as an object to be mastered, and a *mystère*, in which the inquirer is implicated and which cannot be objectified without being destroyed. Whether Herbert encountered Marcel directly or absorbed the distinction through the existentialist idiom of the Slattery circle, its function in the novel is exact. Prescience is the reduction of mystery to problem; it treats the future as an object to be surveyed. Paul's tragedy is that he cannot cease solving what was meant to be lived.

CHAPTER 3

The Sands of Empire

Ibn Khaldun, Lawrence, Blanch, and the Political Theology of Charisma

3.1 The Kitab al-Ibar

Among the entries of *Dune*'s terminology is the *Kitab al-Ibar*, the combined survival manual and religious guide of the Fremen. The title is that of the universal history of the fourteenth-century North African scholar ʿAbd al-Raḥmān Ibn Khaldūn, whose prolegomenon, the *Muqaddimah* (1377), is among the founding texts of historical sociology. The allusion is structural, not decorative. Ibn Khaldun's theory turns on *ʿaṣabiyya*, the group feeling or solidarity that the hardship of desert life forges among nomadic peoples. A people possessed of strong ʿaṣabiyya can conquer sedentary civilizations whose solidarity has been dissolved by luxury; but conquest initiates decline, for the conquerors settle, acquire the refinements of the city, and within roughly three generations lose the solidarity that made their victory possible, whereupon they are conquered in turn by a new people from the desert. History, in this account, is a cycle whose motor is the alternation of scarcity and abundance.

Dune and its first two sequels transpose the *Muqaddimah* into science fiction with remarkable fidelity. The Fremen are ʿaṣabiyya incarnate: their water discipline, their sietch communism, their rendering of the dead's water to the tribe, their law of the duel, and their capacity for coordinated violence are all products of the desert's extremity. Their jihad is the Khaldunian conquest of the city by the steppe. Herbert gives the Khaldunian insight to Duke Leto himself, who tells Hawat that the Atreides, whose supremacy on Caladan rested on sea and air power, must now develop what he calls "desert power" (Book I). The *Kitab al-Ibar*, for its part, is quoted in the novel both as field manual, in a precept on traveling by night and resting in shade by day (Book II), and as social law, in a precept on marriage (Book III): survival and morality bound in a single text, as ʿaṣabiyya requires. *Children of Dune* chronicles, through Leto II's bitter observations, the onset of Khaldunian decline: the Fremen grow soft with water and wealth, the rites of the sietch harden into ceremony, and the young no longer know the deep desert. By *God Emperor of Dune* the last phase has been reached, and the Fremen survive as "Museum Fremen," performing their culture for visitors: ʿaṣabiyya preserved as exhibit. Herbert has written the Khaldunian cycle forward through three thousand years and found, at its end, the problem that the Golden Path addresses, namely how to break a cycle that every prior civilization has repeated.

3.2

The Outsider in the Desert

T. E. Lawrence's *Seven Pillars of Wisdom* (privately printed 1926; published 1935) is the most widely recognized model for Paul: an outsider from an imperial culture who adopts the dress, language, and customs of a desert people, leads them in revolt against an empire, is mythologized by mass media (in Lawrence's case, by Lowell Thomas's illustrated lecture-shows), and is tormented by the knowledge that his charisma serves ends not his followers' own. Lawrence's introductory reflection on the dreamers of the day, those who enact their dreams with open eyes and are therefore dangerous, might serve as epigraph to the entire series, since Paul is a dreamer of the day whose dreams are literally prescient. The decisive difference is that Lawrence left. His revolt was co-opted by Britain and France at the peace settlement, and he retreated into anonymity under assumed names, an abdication that is itself a commentary on charisma. Paul cannot leave: every vision of abdication shows him a worse jihad. Herbert rewrites Lawrence as a man whose exit is foreclosed by foreknowledge, and that foreclosure is the engine of *Dune Messiah*.

3.3

The Sabres of Paradise

The more specific and, until recently, less acknowledged source is Lesley Blanch's *The Sabres of Paradise* (1960), a history of the Imam Shamil and the Murid resistance to the Russian conquest of the Caucasus in the mid-nineteenth century. Will Collins (2017) has documented Herbert's extensive borrowing from Blanch's lexicon and imagery: *kanly*, the formal blood feud, which in *Dune* becomes the regulated vendetta between Great Houses under the Great Convention; *kindjal*, the Caucasian dagger; *Chakobsa*, the hunting language; and a set of aphorisms and customs transposed from mountain to desert. The significance of the source is interpretive as well as philological. Herbert's model for the Fremen is not only the Bedouin of Lawrence's narrative, frozen in Orientalist timelessness, but an anticolonial insurgency: a confederation of mountain peoples united by a militant Sufi order against the expansion of a Christian empire. Shamil's resistance lasted a quarter-century and ended in his capture and honored captivity, an arc that resembles less Paul's triumph than the long Fremen guerrilla against the Harkonnens that precedes it.

3.4

The Messianic Lexicon

Herbert's religious vocabulary is a deliberate syncretism. From Islamic eschatology he takes the *Mahdi*, the rightly guided one expected at the end of time, whose most consequential modern claimant, Muhammad Ahmad of the Sudan (proclaimed 1881), led an anticolonial jihad whose army stormed Khartoum in 1885 after a ten-month siege, killing the governor-general, Charles

Gordon, along with much of the garrison and many of the city's inhabitants; the Fremen's other title for their expected deliverer, *Lisan al-Gaib*, renders an Arabic phrase for the tongue of the unseen, which the glossary notes is sometimes translated "Giver of Water" (Terminology). From Jewish mysticism he takes *Kwisatz Haderach*, a transliteration of *kefitzat haderech*, the contraction of the path: the miraculous shortening of a journey ascribed in rabbinic and Hasidic legend to holy men. Herbert's displacement of the term is exact, for the Kwisatz Haderach shortens the way not through space but through time; he arrives at the future without traversing the interval. The novel performs the translation itself. Jessica first hears the phrase from Liet-Kynes, who at the Arrakeen banquet asks her, unnoticed by the other guests, whether she brings "the shortening of the way," the old tongue's Kwisatz Haderach (Book I); the Reverend Mother and Appendix III gloss the term as one who can be many places at once. The miracle of travel has become the miracle of foresight. From Sunni theology he takes *bi-lā kayfa*, "without asking how," the formula by which the Hanbali and Ashʿari traditions affirmed scriptural attributes of God while declining to specify their modality; the Fremen employ it as their *amen*, signifying that nothing further need be explained. From Christianity he takes the Orange Catholic Bible, product of an ecumenical commission's effort to reconcile the scriptures of the surviving faiths. The effect is a laboratory of comparative religion, a far-future analogue of what Karl Jaspers (*Vom Ursprung und Ziel der Geschichte*, 1949) called the Axial Age, the epoch in which the major religious and philosophical traditions emerged in parallel, now produced not by spontaneous convergence but by administration.

3.5
Charisma and Its Routinization

The theoretical framework that best explains the political trajectory of the first three novels is Max Weber's sociology of domination (*Herrschaft*) in *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft* (1922). Weber distinguished three pure types of legitimate authority: rational-legal, grounded in impersonal rules; traditional, grounded in the sanctity of inherited custom; and charismatic, grounded in devotion to the extraordinary qualities of an individual. Charisma, in Weber's analysis, is revolutionary, anti-economic, and inherently unstable. It must continually prove itself (*Bewährung*), and it cannot survive its bearer unless it is routinized (*veralltäglicht*) into tradition or bureaucracy, a process that preserves charisma's legitimating force by betraying its spirit. *Dune Messiah* is Weber's theory rendered as narrative. The Qizarate, Muad'Dib's priestly bureaucracy, converts his charisma into an apparatus he cannot control; Irulan's histories, whose epigraphs frame the first novel, are the scripture of routinized charisma; Alia's regency in *Children of Dune* is charisma become a church with an army. Herbert compresses into one figure the two moments that Christian history distributes between two persons: Paul Atreides is at once the charismatic founder and, in the Qizarate he authorizes, his own Paul of Tarsus, the organizer of the church. The shared name is unlikely to be accidental. Appendix II closes by attributing to the Bene Ges-

serit a maxim that compresses Weber's theory into a sentence: when religion and politics ride in the same cart, and a living holy man drives it, nothing can stand in their path. The Sisterhood possessed the formula for charisma; what it failed to foresee was that the driver would be its own creature.

Two further theorists sharpen the analysis. Eric Hoffer's *The True Believer* (1951) argued that fanaticisms are interchangeable, that the true believer seeks above all to dissolve a spoiled self into a collective cause, and that mass movements require a devil as much as a god; the jihad's absorption of disparate peoples into a single fervor directed against the Harkonnen and Corrino enemy follows Hoffer's model closely. Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) opened with the claim that sovereign is he who decides on the exception, and argued that the significant concepts of modern state theory are secularized theological concepts. Paul's seizure of power at the close of *Dune* is a Schmittian decision. He claims sovereignty by demonstrating that he can destroy the spice, reasoning that the one who can destroy a thing holds the real control of it. Sovereignty is thereby defined as the capacity to annihilate the commons on which all depend, a definition to which Chapter 9 returns.

3.6
The Orientalism Question

Said's *Orientalism* (1978) identified a Western discursive formation that represented the East as exotic, static, sensual, and irrational, available to be known and governed by the West. The charge that *Dune* participates in this formation has substance. The Fremen are rendered largely through the perceptions of off-world aristocrats; their culture is assembled from Arabic, Persian, and Caucasian fragments detached from their historical contexts; and the plot in which an outsider becomes the messiah of a desert people reproduces the structure of the white-savior narrative. Against this, a persistent counter-reading, Herbert's own among them, holds that the novel deploys the savior narrative in order to indict it: the outsider's ascent is the catastrophe, and the Fremen's acceptance of him the beginning of their destruction.

This dissertation proposes that the two readings are reconciled, and both deepened, by a chronoecological frame. The anthropologist Johannes Fabian's *Time and the Other* (1983) argued that colonial knowledge characteristically denies "coevalness" to its objects, placing them in another time, a past or a primitive stage, than that of the observer. The Missionaria Protectiva denies the Fremen coevalness with exemplary efficiency: it scripts their future in advance, so that when the off-world messiah arrives, the Fremen are already living inside a narrative written for them by others. The novel documents the scripting at every level. The Reverend Mother tells Jessica that the Missionaria Protectiva has been on Arrakis and has softened it up (Book I); an Irulan epigraph records that the prophetic legends took hold even to the adoption of labels, among them Reverend Mother and most of the Shari-a and panoplia propheticus (Book I); and Appendix II notes that the Fremen Hymn to Water is copied directly from the Orange Catholic Liturgical

Manual, a prayer for rain clouds Arrakis has never seen. A desert people has been taught to pray for another world's weather. Colonialism in *Dune* is not only the appropriation of territory and resource but the appropriation of a people's future. Paul's prescience completes what the Missionaria Protectiva began; the Fremen future is the commons his foresight extracts. The Orientalist critique and the anti-savior reading are thus not opposed but successive descriptions of a single operation, which Part III names prescient extraction.

CHAPTER 4

The Planetologist's Ethic

Florence, Sears, Leopold, and the Petro-Ecology of Arrakis

4.1 The Moving Sands

In 1957 Herbert traveled to Florence, Oregon, to report on a United States Department of Agriculture project that stabilized migrating coastal dunes by planting European beach grass. The article he drafted, "They Stopped the Moving Sands," was never published, but the assignment supplied the founding intuition of *Dune*: that a desert is not a static absence of life but a dynamic system, its dunes moving like slow waves capable of engulfing roads, forests, and towns, and that a sufficiently patient ecological intervention can redirect its flows. Herbert's speculative biology then performs a radical inversion. On Arrakis, aridity is not a geological given but a biological artifact. The sandtrout, larval vector of the sandworm, encysts free water across the planet and sequesters it beneath the sand, producing the desert the adult worm requires. The pre-spice mass, a fungoid eruption fed by the sandtrout's metabolic products, explodes in the spice blow, and melange is its residue. The planet is dry because its keystone organism keeps it dry. In this closed loop, in which worm produces desert, desert produces worm, and both produce spice, Herbert anticipated the central claim of James Lovelock's Gaia hypothesis (formulated in the early 1970s and elaborated in *Gaia*, 1979): that a planetary environment can be actively regulated by its biota. Arrakis is a Gaian planet whose homeostatic setpoint is aridity.

4.2 Deserts on the March

The intellectual context of Herbert's desert is American ecology's reckoning with the Dust Bowl. Paul B. Sears's *Deserts on the March* (1935) argued that the catastrophe of the southern plains was anthropogenic, that agricultural practice ignorant of ecological limits can manufacture deserts, and that a civilization's survival depends on understanding the land as a system. *Dune* inverts the vector without abandoning the premise. The imperial planetologist Pardot Kynes, discovering the water locked within Arrakis, conceives a plan to make the planet habitable through dew precipitators, windtraps, and the patient planting of dune-anchoring grasses, a project measured in centuries, which he frames, tellingly, as an "open-end prediction" to five hundred years (Appendix I). He recruits the Fremen to it and in doing so becomes their prophet: the ecological plan

becomes a religion, and the dream of open water a messianic expectation in its own right. His son, Liet-Kynes, inherits both the science and the leadership, and his death in the deep desert, hearing his dead father's voice recite the maxim that the highest function of ecology is understanding consequences as a spice blow rises beneath him (Book II), is one of the novel's great set pieces of science become faith.

The Kynes doctrine, preserved in the first appendix, holds that the highest function of ecology is the understanding of consequences. This principle connects *Dune* to the systems ecology consolidated in Eugene P. Odum's *Fundamentals of Ecology* (1953), which reconceived ecosystems as networks of energy and material flow, and to Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948), whose concepts of feedback and homeostasis gave mid-century science a vocabulary for self-regulating systems. Herbert, a computer enthusiast who would later coauthor a guide to home computing (Herbert and Barnard 1980), thought of planets and societies alike as feedback systems whose interventions propagate along unexpected loops.

4.3
Thinking Like a Mountain

Aldo Leopold's *A Sand County Almanac* (1949) supplies the ethical complement to Sears's diagnosis. Its land ethic proposes that an action is right when it tends to preserve the integrity, stability, and beauty of the biotic community, and wrong when it tends otherwise. Its most celebrated essay, "Thinking Like a Mountain," recounts Leopold's youthful killing of a wolf, the fierce green fire dying in her eyes, and his later recognition that the extermination of wolves, undertaken to multiply deer for hunters, produced irruptions of deer that stripped the mountain of its vegetation, so that the herds themselves starved and the slopes eroded. Only the mountain, Leopold suggests, has lived long enough to hear the wolf's howl objectively. To think like a mountain is to evaluate action on the timescale of ecological consequence rather than of human desire.

The structural homology between Leopold's parable and the ecological plot of the Dune series has not, to my knowledge, been systematically developed, and it is the foundation of Part III. The Fremen dream of a green Arrakis is, in Leopold's terms, the extermination of the wolf. A verdant planet would destroy the sandworm, whose habitat is the desert; the loss of the worm would end the production of spice; the end of spice would collapse the Guild's navigation, the Bene Gesserit's access to Other Memory, the longevity of the aristocracy, and the interstellar unity of the Imperium; and the end of the desert would dissolve the Fremen themselves, whose culture is an adaptation to scarcity. The first novel already registers the danger at the level of biochemistry. Appendix I reports that at the desert edge of the plantings the sand plankton is being poisoned through interaction with the new forms of life, a protein incompatibility that turns water itself to poison at the margin of the green. The ecological liberation is, from its first successes, an autoimmune event. *Children of Dune* makes the danger explicit: the terraforming is succeeding, the worms are retreating, and Leto II perceives that his father's people's ecological dream is a

slow catastrophe. His response, to merge with the sandtrout and become over three millennia the last and greatest worm, is, as Chapter 11 argues, the act of a sovereign who has learned to think like a mountain, or rather like a desert.

4.4

Silent Spring and the Ecology of Consequence

Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring* (1962), published as Herbert was completing *Dune*, demonstrated that chemical interventions propagate through food webs to produce effects remote in space and time from their causes. Carson helped transform ecology from a scientific specialty into a public ethic, and *Dune*'s reception was carried on the same current: the novel circulated in the counterculture associated with Stewart Brand's *Whole Earth Catalog*, and Herbert appeared at the inaugural Earth Day of 1970 and edited the anthology *New World or No World* issued in connection with it. Herbert's distinctive contribution to this ethic, however, is anti-utopian. The ecology of consequence applies to ecologists. Kynes's plan, conceived as liberation, is a messianism in its own right (it is Liet-Kynes, the imperial planetologist, and not a Fremen priest, who first asks Jessica whether she brings the shortening of the way), and Herbert distrusts the planetologist as much as the prophet, not because ecological knowledge is false, but because any total plan, scientific or religious, converts a living system's open future into a project.

4.5

Petro-Ecology: The Spice Must Flow

Melange is at once the novel's most transparent allegory and its most frequently underread. A single substance, found on a single planet in a single arid region inhabited by a tribal people whom the off-world powers regard as primitive, sustains an interstellar civilization's transport, longevity, and cognition. Access to it is the object of the great houses' rivalry; its trade is administered by a monopoly combine (CHOAM) in which the emperor and the great houses hold shares; its interruption would bring the civilization to a halt. The parallel with the political economy of Middle Eastern oil in the 1950s and early 1960s (the 1953 overthrow of Iran's prime minister Mohammad Mosaddegh in a coup organized by the CIA and British intelligence after he nationalized the Anglo-Iranian Oil Company; the 1956 invasion of Egypt by Britain, France, and Israel after Gamal Abdel Nasser nationalized the Suez Canal; the founding of OPEC in 1960) is direct. CHOAM resembles less a modern corporation than the chartered companies of early modern empire, the Dutch and English East India Companies, sovereign-commercial hybrids in which trade and rule are indistinguishable. Arrakis exhibits the resource curse in its purest form: its inhabitants are impoverished by the wealth beneath them, and the Harkonnen administration is an extractive regime in the strict sense, one that makes terror a policy: the Baron sets his nephew Glossu Rabban to crush the population so that his other nephew, Feyd-Rautha, can later be welcomed as its deliverer, a manufactured savior in miniature.

Amitav Ghosh coined the term *petrofiction* (1992) in a review of Abdelrahman Munif's *Cities of Salt* (1984), lamenting the scarcity of fiction adequate to the oil encounter. Munif's novel, which narrates the arrival of American oil prospectors in a Bedouin oasis and the dissolution of a desert society under extraction, is the realist counterpart of *Dune*; Herbert's novel, written two decades earlier, is arguably the genre's speculative masterpiece. What Herbert adds to the petropolitical allegory is the substance's metaphysical property. Oil fuels movement; melange fuels foresight. The Guild navigator, saturated in spice gas, perceives the safe paths through space before the ship traverses them. The commodity on which the Imperium depends is, quite literally, the future in solid form. Chapter 9 draws the consequences.

CHAPTER 5

Machines and Bloodlines

Butler, Mumford, Plato, Galton, Nietzsche

5.1 Darwin among the Machines

Ten thousand years before the events of *Dune*, according to its appendices, humanity waged a crusade against thinking machines, computers and conscious robots, whose chief commandment, preserved in the Orange Catholic Bible, forbids the making of a machine in the likeness of the human mind. The glossary dates the crusade from 201 to 108 B.G., in a calendar reckoned from the Spacing Guild's founding, and Appendix II remembers it as two generations of chaos. Herbert left the in-universe etymology of the "Butlerian" Jihad unexplained (the posthumous prequels supply an eponym of their own invention), but the allusion to Samuel Butler is unmistakable. In "Darwin among the Machines" (1863), a letter to the Christchurch *Press*, and in the "Book of the Machines" chapters of *Erewhon* (1872), Butler applied the logic of natural selection to technology. Machines, he argued, were evolving with a rapidity that would eventually render humans their servants, and the only safe course was their destruction; the Erewhonians had taken that course, abolishing all machines invented within the preceding centuries.

Herbert was no Erewhonian. He was a computer enthusiast; his *Destination: Void* (1966) imagines the engineering of an artificial consciousness, and its sequel, *The Jesus Incident* (1979, with Bill Ransom), imagines the consequences when that consciousness becomes a god demanding worship. The Butlerian Jihad is therefore not a technophobic policy endorsed by its author but a thought experiment: what would humanity become if it forbade itself the externalization of cognition? Leto II's later gloss in *God Emperor of Dune* is decisive. The target of the Jihad, he observes, was a machine-attitude as much as the machines themselves: the use of machines by some humans to dominate others, and the habit of mind that delegates judgment to devices.

5.2 The Megamachine Made of Men

The answer *Dune* gives to its own thought experiment is that the machine returned in the flesh. Lewis Mumford's *The Myth of the Machine* (vol. 1, *Technics and Human Development*, 1967; vol. 2, *The Pentagon of Power*, 1970) argued that the first complex machine in human history was

composed not of metal but of people: the "megamachine" of the Bronze Age god-kings, which organized vast armies of laborers, soldiers, scribes, and priests into standardized, interchangeable components under a divine sovereign, and which raised the pyramids before any mechanical engine existed. Mumford's thesis, published as Herbert was writing the first sequels, describes the post-Butlerian Imperium with uncanny precision. The Mentat is a human computer. The Guild navigator, mutated by spice into a creature of tank and gas, is a human guidance system. The Bene Gesserit truthsayer is a human lie detector. The Suk physician, conditioned against betrayal, is a human safety interlock. The Sardaukar, forged on the prison planet Salusa Secundus, are human weapons. The Tleilaxu axlotl tanks, revealed in the late novels to be the bodies of Tleilaxu women, are human factories. Appendix III removes any doubt that the post-Butlerian order dreams of the forbidden machine in flesh: the Bene Gesserit, it reports, were breeding for a "super-Mentat," a human computer with some of the prescience of Guild navigators. The Kwisatz Haderach is the Butlerian prohibition's return in genetic form. And at the apex, in *God Emperor of Dune*, stands Mumford's god-king, Leto II, orchestrating the megamachine for three and a half millennia.

Heidegger's lecture "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954), which Herbert's exposure to Heidegger through the Slatterys renders at least a plausible remote source, supplies the ontological description. The essence of modern technology, Heidegger argued, is not any instrument but *Gestell*, "enframing," a mode of revealing in which everything, the human included, appears as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, a stock of resources on call for optimization. The Butlerian Jihad abolished the instruments and preserved the enframing. Its consequence, a civilization that, having expelled its machines, converted its own members into them, is the first instance of the autoimmune pattern that Chapter 10 generalizes.

5.3

The Breeders: Plato's Guardians

Book V of Plato's *Republic* introduces three "waves" of paradox that Socrates must surmount. The first is that women shall be guardians on equal terms with men. The second is that the guardians shall hold spouses and children in common, their unions arranged by the rulers through rigged lotteries designed to mate the best with the best while concealing the design (459d–460b). The third and greatest is that philosophers must become kings or kings philosophers. Earlier, in Book III (414b–415d), Socrates proposes the noble lie, the myth of the metals, by which citizens are taught that the gods mixed gold, silver, or bronze into their souls so that each will accept his station.

The Bene Gesserit are Plato's Book V realized as an institution, and realized as a female order, so that Plato's first wave is not merely admitted but made sovereign. The Sisterhood arranges the matings of the great houses over ninety generations according to a design concealed from the participants, in pursuit of a philosopher-king, the Kwisatz Haderach, whom it intends to control. Its

Missionaria Protectiva is the noble lie at interstellar scale: myths implanted in primitive cultures to secure the order's future safety and authority. That the Kwisatz Haderach escapes control, arriving a generation early because Jessica, out of love for Duke Leto, bore a son rather than the ordered daughter, is Herbert's verdict on the Platonic program. Appendix III states the stakes with archival dryness. The Atreides line had been watched for more than a thousand years; Jessica's gene-markers had been known for almost two thousand; her ordered daughter was to be bred to Feyd-Rautha; and Jessica bore a son instead, for reasons she confesses have never been completely clear to her. The eugenic plan fails at the moment of its success, and it fails because an unscheduled affection introduced a variable no breeder could foresee. Love, in *Dune*, is the mutation that breaks the program.

5.4

Galton and the Genetic Imaginary

Francis Galton's *Hereditary Genius* (1869) and *Inquiries into Human Faculty and Its Development* (1883), in which he coined the word "eugenics," inaugurated the modern project of improving human stock by selective breeding, a project that culminated within decades in state violence: more than 60,000 forced sterilizations in the United States under state laws the Supreme Court upheld in 1927; some 63,000 sterilizations in Sweden between 1935 and 1975, many of them coerced; and, under National Socialism, the forced sterilization of roughly 400,000 people, the murder of disabled patients in the T4 program and its successors, and a doctrine of racial hygiene that helped supply the ideological warrant for the murder of six million European Jews. Writing two decades after the Holocaust, Herbert treated the genetic imaginary with a mixture of fascination and dread that the series never resolves. The Bene Gesserit program is presented with admiration for its patience and horror at its instrumentalism; the Bene Tleilax are geneticists without scruple, producing gholas from the cells of the dead and Face Dancers who can assume any shape; the Sardaukar are bred by ordeal on a prison world. Herbert's most subversive move is reserved for *God Emperor of Dune*, in which Leto II conducts his own breeding program for thirty-five centuries, culminating in Siona Atreides, whose defining trait is invisibility to prescience. The program is eugenic in method and anti-eugenic in telos: it breeds for unbreedability, for a humanity that no future breeder, and no future prophet, can see or steer.

5.5

Nietzsche: Übermensch, Breeding, Eternal Return

Nietzsche's *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883–85) proclaims the *Übermensch* as the meaning of the earth, the being who will overcome the human as the human overcame the ape; his later writings, notably *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (1886), speak of *Züchtung*, the cultivation or breeding of a higher type. In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882, §341), Nietzsche poses the thought of eternal recur-

rence as a test: whether one could will one's life, every pain and every joy in the same sequence, to return infinitely. The affirmative answer is *amor fati*, the love of fate.

The Dune series stages a critique of the Übermensch in Nietzsche's own terms. The Kwisatz Haderach is the bred superman, and Herbert's verdict is that the superman is not humanity's goal but its gravest danger. Eternal recurrence, for Leto II, is not a thought experiment but a condition. He carries within him every ancestral life, and he perceives the whole of human history as the recurrence of a single cycle (empire, stagnation, messiah, jihad, routinization, empire) that Ibn Khaldun had already described. Paul refuses *amor fati*: he struggles against his vision and is broken by it. Leto embraces it, but his love of fate is strategic rather than ecstatic, directed toward the one future in which fate ends. The Golden Path is the Übermensch's self-overcoming in the most literal sense: a superman whose final work is a humanity without supermen.

5.6

The Human Park

Peter Sloterdijk's lecture *Regeln für den Menschenpark* (1999), which provoked a scandal in Germany for its discussion of genetic selection, argued that humanism had always been a technology of taming, a set of practices, chiefly literacy, by which humans domesticated humans, and read Plato's *Statesman* as a treatise on the husbandry of a human herd. Sloterdijk's provocation names the political form of *God Emperor of Dune*. Leto II's Imperium is a *Menschenpark*, a human preserve administered by a single keeper: travel is restricted, spice is hoarded, the population is policed by the Fish Speakers, the Atreides lines are bred, the Fremen are curated as museum pieces, and the deep desert of the Sareer is preserved as wilderness. The paradox that Part III resolves is that this park is administered for the sake of its own abolition. The keeper domesticates the herd in order to release it feral.

II

PART II

Comparative Morphologies

Comparative morphology, as practiced here, sets Dune *beside works with which it shares a problem rather than a lineage. Three problematics organize the comparison: prediction, the knowability and manipulability of the future (Chapter 6); messianism, the relation between extraordinary individuals and the masses who invest them with meaning (Chapter 7); and the relation of planets to minds, encompassing ecology, terraforming, and the delegation of cognition to nonhuman intelligences (Chapter 8). In each case the comparison is designed to isolate the specificity of Herbert's solution.*

CHAPTER 6

The Calculus of the Future

Asimov, Le Guin, Borges, Chiang, Liu, Vonnegut

6.1 Psychohistory and the Mule

Isaac Asimov's Foundation stories (1942–50; collected 1951–53) constitute *Dune*'s most important antagonist in the field. Both are rewritings of Gibbon: galactic empires in decline, populated exclusively by humans, without aliens and, in the original Foundation trilogy as in *Dune*, without robots. Both center on a long-range plan for managing the interregnum. Their epistemologies, however, are opposed. Hari Seldon's psychohistory predicts the behavior of masses statistically, on two conditions: the population must be large enough for individual variation to cancel out, and it must remain ignorant of the predictions. Its nemesis is the Mule, a mutant whose power over emotion introduces a variable no statistical model can absorb; its guardian is the Second Foundation, a concealed elite of mentalics who tend the Plan in secret.

Herbert's system maps onto Asimov's with inverted signs. The Bene Gesserit are a Second Foundation: a hidden order, possessed of extraordinary mental disciplines, managing history across millennia. The Kwisatz Haderach is a Mule, a mutant individual who seizes the galaxy, with the decisive irony that he is the *planned* Mule, the product of the very order that would manage him, arriving early. Where Asimov locates prediction in the aggregate and danger in the individual, Herbert locates prediction in the individual and danger in the aggregate he can foresee and therefore command. The deepest contrast emerges in the late phase of each oeuvre. In *Foundation's Edge* (1982) and *Foundation and Earth* (1986), Asimov's answer to the instability of history is Galaxia, a galaxy-wide collective consciousness in which every being participates in a single mind. Herbert's answer, in *God Emperor of Dune* (1981), is the Scattering, the dispersal of humanity beyond the reach of any single mind. Asimov's end is unification; Herbert's is dissemination. Leto II performs psychohistory as a single consciousness for thirty-five centuries in order to produce a humanity to which psychohistory can no longer apply: too dispersed to be modeled as an aggregate and, in Siona's descendants, invisible to the observer. Seldon designs for predictability; Leto designs for its abolition.

6.2

The Foretellers of Gethen

In Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969), the envoy Genly Ai visits the Handdara Fastness of Otherhord, where a circle of Foretellers led by the Weaver Faxe can answer any question about the future with certainty. The Handdara, however, value foretelling for a reason that inverts its apparent purpose: they practice it to demonstrate the uselessness of answers to the wrong questions, and they hold that what makes life possible is precisely the permanent and intolerable uncertainty of not knowing what comes next. Le Guin's Taoist anti-prescience and Herbert's tragic anti-prescience converge on the same verdict, that certainty is a form of death, from opposite directions. Le Guin's Foretellers possess foresight and decline to be governed by it; Herbert's prescients possess foresight and cannot escape its government. What Le Guin reaches by way of the *Tao Te Ching*, Herbert reaches by way of Sophocles.

6.3

Borges: Labyrinths of Time and Memory

Three *ficciones* of Jorge Luis Borges anticipate Herbert's problems with an economy no novelist could match. In "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941), the sinologist Stephen Albert reveals that Ts'ui Pên's apparently chaotic novel is a labyrinth of time in which all possible outcomes of every choice occur, each generating further bifurcations. Paul's prescient vision is a garden of forking paths that narrows with every choice he makes (an Irulan epigraph gives the figure its plainest form: the vision of time is broad, but to pass through it is to find time become a narrow door, Book II); by *Dune Messiah* it has narrowed to a single path he can see but not leave, and the Golden Path is, in Borges's figure, the one fork among innumerable forks in which humanity survives. In "Funes el memorioso" (1942), Ireneo Funes acquires perfect memory after a fall and loses the capacity to think, since thought requires forgetting differences in order to generalize; Funes dies young, crushed by particulars. Other Memory is the Funes problem raised to the power of ancestry, and Alia's Abomination is Funes possessed by his own archive. In "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940), a secret society invents a world so coherent that its artifacts begin to appear in, and then to replace, reality. The Missionaria Protectiva's planted prophecies, which the Fremen take for revelation and which then become the reality Paul inhabits, are Tlön realized: a fiction devised by a secret society supplanting the world.

6.4

Chiang: The Variational Mind and the Predictor

Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) is the most philosophically rigorous treatment of foreknowledge in contemporary speculative fiction. The linguist Louise Banks, in learning the written language of the heptapods, acquires their simultaneous mode of consciousness, which corres-

ponds to the variational formulation of physics: Fermat's principle that light follows the path of least time, a formulation that presents physical processes as though purposive, the endpoint known in advance. Louise comes to perceive her life whole, including her daughter's death, and chooses to enact it; freedom becomes the performance of a known script, and the meaning of an act lies in its actualization rather than in any selection among alternatives. Chiang's short-short "What's Expected of Us" (2005) presents the obverse. The Predictor, a device whose light flashes one second before its button is pressed, demonstrates that free will is illusory, and those who play with it sink into akinetic mutism.

Paul occupies the terrain between these two stories. In *Dune Messiah*, blinded by a stone burner, he moves through Arrakeen guided by vision, enacting each foreseen moment with a precision that horrifies his companions: Louise's script performed without Louise's serenity. And in the terror of the Guild and the Bene Gesserit before the futures he forecloses, the Predictor's paralysis appears at the scale of institutions. Leto II's acceptance of the Golden Path is neither serenity nor paralysis but strategy. He performs the script because it contains, at its terminus, the end of scripts.

6.5
Liu Cixin: The Wallfacer and the Dark Forest

In Liu Cixin's 黑暗森林 (*The Dark Forest*, 2008), the Trisolarans' sophons, protons unfolded into planetary computers, can observe all human communication and action but not human thought. Humanity responds with the Wallfacer Project: four individuals granted unlimited resources to devise strategies that exist only in their own minds, concealed even from those who execute them. Leto II is a Wallfacer *avant la lettre*. His strategy exists only in his consciousness and in journals hidden at Dar-es-Balat; his instruments (Moneo, the serial Duncan Idaho gholas, the Fish Speakers) execute fragments of a plan they cannot see; and his adversaries, the Bene Gesserit, Ix, and the Tleilaxu, operate within a field of near-total observation. Liu's sophons and Herbert's prescience are cognate figures for a regime in which the only unobservable space is interiority. The solutions diverge instructively. Liu's Luo Ji prevails by discovering the cosmic sociology of the dark forest, a universe in which every civilization hides because to be seen is to be destroyed, and by threatening mutual exposure. Leto prevails by breeding interiority into the species' genome: Siona's descendants carry as heredity the unobservability that the Wallfacer must preserve by will.

6.6
Vonnegut: Prescience as Farce

Kurt Vonnegut's *The Sirens of Titan* (1959), published six years before *Dune*, contains in comic form nearly all of *Dune*'s elements. Winston Niles Rumfoord, having flown his spacecraft into a chrono-synclastic infundibulum, exists as a wave phenomenon spread across space and time and

can see the future. He uses his foresight to stage a doomed Martian invasion of Earth, whose purpose is to unite humanity in guilt, and founds the Church of God the Utterly Indifferent. The narrative then reveals that all of human history, Rumfoord's manipulations included, has been engineered by the Tralfamadorians to deliver a replacement part to a stranded robot messenger. Prescience, engineered religion, and history as the instrument of an alien design: *The Sirens of Titan* is the satyr play that precedes Herbert's tragedy. Vonnegut's conclusion, that the purpose of human life is to love whoever is near to be loved, is humanist and local; Herbert's, as Part III argues, is evolutionary and planetary. Both agree that a history known in advance is a history in which human beings are reduced to parts.

CHAPTER 7

Messiahs and Their Discontents

Dostoevsky, Heinlein, Clarke, Dick, Wolfe, Octavia E. Butler, Tolkien, Stapledon

7.1
The Grand Inquisitor

THE CHAPTER of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880) in which Ivan Karamazov recites his prose poem of the Grand Inquisitor is the indispensable intertext for the late Dune novels. Christ returns to sixteenth-century Seville, is recognized by the people, and is arrested by the aged Cardinal Inquisitor, who explains why he must burn. In rejecting the three temptations in the wilderness, Christ offered humanity a freedom it cannot bear; the Church has corrected his work, ruling humanity through miracle, mystery, and authority, giving it bread and the consolation of submission, while the Inquisitor and his fellow rulers bear the burden of knowledge and freedom on behalf of the happy, unfree millions. Christ answers nothing. He kisses the old man, who releases him into the dark.

The religion of Muad'Dib supplies exactly the Inquisitor's three powers: miracle (prescience, the riding of worms, survival of the Water of Life), mystery (the Water of Life itself, the rites of the sietch, the Kwisatz Haderach), and authority (the Qizarate, the Fedaykin, the jihad). Leto II is the Grand Inquisitor who has read Dostoevsky. He rules by miracle, mystery, and authority for thirty-five centuries, not to spare humanity the burden of freedom but to make the unfreedom of the Inquisitor's regime so total, so intimate, and so prolonged that humanity acquires an ineradicable aversion to it, so that, once released, it will never again accept a messiah. Leto composes both the Inquisitor's speech and Christ's silence: the speech is his reign, and the silence is the future he cannot see, which belongs to Siona.

7.2
Water Brothers: Heinlein's Stranger

Robert A. Heinlein's *Stranger in a Strange Land* (1961), whose messiah Valentine Michael Smith is raised by Martians and returns to Earth to found the Church of All Worlds, shares with *Dune* a detail that has received surprisingly little attention: both of the period's great science-fiction messiahs emerge from water-scarce cultures in which the sharing of water constitutes sacred kinship. Smith's "water brothers" and the Fremen's water-bond, which encompasses the rendering of the dead's water to the tribe and the tears Paul sheds for Jamis that the Fremen receive as a gift of

moisture to the dead, are cognate rituals of a scarcity-born communion. The two messiahs then diverge. Smith teaches "grokking," a total empathic understanding, is martyred, and his church flourishes; the novel's countercultural readers took it as a celebration, and it inspired a real-world church of the same name. Paul survives his triumph, presides over a jihad, and is destroyed by the routinization of his own charisma. Heinlein's is the libertarian messianism of the 1960s; Herbert's is the libertarian anti-messianism that answered it.

7.3
Childhood's End

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) narrates the arrival of the Overlords, who abolish war and want on Earth in order to shepherd humanity's children through their metamorphosis into the Overmind, a cosmic collective intelligence; the human species, as such, ends. Clarke treats transcendence with melancholy but without suspicion. Herbert treats it with unrelenting suspicion. In *Dune*, Paul perceives a race consciousness, a collective will of the species driving toward the jihad as a means of genetic renewal, and he experiences it as the most terrible of compulsions. The Golden Path is, in this light, the anti-Overmind: where Clarke's humanity ends by merging, Herbert's survives by scattering. Taken with Asimov's Galaxia (Chapter 6), Clarke's Overmind reveals a recurrent temptation of mid-century science fiction, the dream of a collective mind as the telos of history, against which Herbert's dispersal stands as the major dissent.

7.4
The Test of the Human: Dick

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) contains the only test of humanity in science fiction to rival the gom jabbar in philosophical consequence. The Voigt-Kampff test distinguishes humans from androids by measuring involuntary empathic responses, capillary dilation and pupillary fluctuation, to descriptions of animal suffering. The comparison crystallizes two anthropologies. The gom jabbar defines the human by the capacity to withhold response, to hold pain in awareness without reacting; the Voigt-Kampff defines the human by the capacity to respond involuntarily to another's pain. Herbert's human is the self-mastered animal, Dick's the co-suffering one. The divergence is not absolute, since both locate humanity in a relation to pain, but it determines the political horizon of each: Herbert's anthropology yields an aristocracy of discipline, Dick's a democracy of vulnerability.

Dick's Mercerism, a religion of shared suffering experienced through the empathy box, exposed within the novel as a fraud staged by an actor yet experientially undiminished by the exposure, is the closest analogue in the field to the Missionaria Protectiva's planted religion, which remains a living faith for the Fremen even after its engineering is known to the reader. Dick's late Gnostic novel *VALIS* (1981), with its revelation that the Roman Empire never ended but persists as a Black Iron Prison of time, illuminates the ten-thousand-year continuity of Herbert's Imperi-

um: a history that has ceased to change, a time become a prison. Leto II builds the Black Iron Prison deliberately, so that its inmates may learn to escape it.

7.5

The Autarch and the Alzabo: Wolfe

Gene Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83) follows Severian, a journeyman torturer gifted with perfect memory, who rises to become Autarch of the Commonwealth. Along the way he consumes, with the alzabo's analeptic, the flesh of his beloved Thecla and absorbs her memories into his own; on his accession he inherits the minds of his predecessors, so that the Autarch is a compound consciousness, a multitude in one body. Severian is also a messianic figure, destined to bring the New Sun that will renew a dying world at the cost of drowning its continents. The parallels with Leto II are structural (perfect memory, an interior multitude, a sovereignty grounded in that multitude, an apocalypse that is also a renewal), and the divergence is theological. Wolfe's vision is sacramental: the ingestion of the dead is communion, and the compound self figures the communion of saints. Herbert's is pathological and political: the ingestion of the dead is possession, and the compound self must be governed or it will govern.

7.6

The Breeder and the Seed: Octavia E. Butler

Octavia E. Butler's *Wild Seed* (1980) introduces Doro, an entity nearly four thousand years old who survives by killing one human host after another and taking each body for his own, and who has spent millennia breeding human lineages for psychic power by coercion, compelling matings and killing those who defy him, and Anyanwu, a shape-shifting healer he seeks to incorporate into his program. Doro is a darker Leto II, an immortal breeder for whom human lineages are instruments of his own continuance, and the contrast clarifies Leto's distinctiveness: Doro breeds for power over the bred, Leto for the escape of the bred from his power. Butler's perspective, moreover, is that of the bred. Anyanwu's resistance, negotiation, and partial victory give voice to the subjects whom Herbert's narrative, focalized through breeders and sovereigns, renders largely as material. In *Parable of the Sower* (1993), Butler's Lauren Olamina founds Earthseed, a religion whose god is Change and whose destiny is to take root among the stars: a theology of dispersal that is the Scattering conceived from below. And the Oankali of the Xenogenesis trilogy (1987–89), who diagnose humanity's fatal contradiction, intelligence placed in the service of hierarchical behavior, and compel its genetic hybridization, are Leto II imagined as an alien species: a benevolent coercion that the novels neither endorse nor simply condemn.

7.7

Refusals: Tolkien and Stapledon

J. R. R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* (1954–55) offers a counter-ethic of refusal. Gandalf will not take the Ring; Galadriel, offered it, beholds the terrible queen she would become, declines, and declares the trial passed. Paul cannot refuse, because his foresight shows him that every refusal produces a worse future. The difference is not that Tolkien's wise are wiser but that they do not know the future; their refusal is an act of faith in an outcome they cannot see. Prescience, in Herbert, abolishes the possibility of such faith, and that abolition is its most terrible cost. Yet the climax of *Dune* is a sequence of refusals by others. Thufir Hawat, commanded by the Emperor to use a poisoned needle against Paul, displays it unused and dies in Paul's arms rather than betray the Atreides; Count Hasimir Fenring, ordered by the Emperor to kill Paul, answers that he must refuse; and Paul himself declines the implanted word that would paralyze Feyd-Rautha (Book III). The refusals Herbert denies his prescient hero he grants to those whom prescience cannot command and, in Fenring's case, cannot even see. Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935), whose supernormal protagonist founds a colony of superhumans on a Pacific island and destroys it rather than submit when the world's navies come for them, supplies the other limit: the superman's self-extinction as the only ethical response to the impossibility of coexistence. Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937), with their vistas of successive human species across two billion years, supply the scale against which Leto's thirty-five centuries must be measured: a single consciousness compressing into one life the evolutionary panorama Stapledon distributed across eons.

CHAPTER 8

Planets and Minds

Le Guin, Robinson, Lem, Miller, Banks, Simmons, and Herbert Against Herbert

8.1

Anarres and Arrakis

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) sets its anarchist society on Anarres, an arid moon whose scarcity produces both solidarity and a creeping conformity: less than two centuries after its founding, Odonian society has ossified into an informal bureaucracy of opinion that punishes deviation through social pressure. The parallel with the Fremen is close (scarcity-forged solidarity, a revolutionary founding, a routinization that betrays the founding spirit), and the difference is instructive. Le Guin's remedy is permanent revolution conducted horizontally, by individuals such as the physicist Shevek who refuse the consensus; Herbert's, in the Golden Path, is imposed vertically by a sovereign. Shevek's General Temporal Theory, which unifies the rival physics of Sequency and Simultaneity, is also a political theory: Le Guin's novel argues that freedom requires both the commitment that binds time sequentially, the promise, and the simultaneity that keeps all moments present. It is the closest thing in the field to a chronoecology, and its conclusion, that a society must preserve its capacity for renewal by keeping its future open to its members' choices, is the democratic form of the problem Herbert poses as tragedy.

Le Guin's *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972) completes the comparison. On the forest world Athshe, Terran loggers force a dreaming people into slave labor, and Captain Davidson, who commands one of the logging camps, rapes Selver's wife, who dies; Selver answers by leading the Athsheans in killing the colonists, and so becomes a "god," a translator who brings a new thing into his people's world: killing. Having learned to kill, the Athsheans cannot unlearn it. Selver is Paul in miniature, and Le Guin's verdict coincides with Herbert's: the leader who teaches his people a new capacity for violence alters their future irreversibly.

8.2

Red and Green: Robinson's Mars

Kim Stanley Robinson's Mars trilogy (*Red Mars*, 1992; *Green Mars*, 1993; *Blue Mars*, 1996) is the field's most sustained treatment of the ethics of terraforming, and it stages explicitly the dialectic latent in *Dune*. Ann Clayborne, the geologist, defends the Red position: Mars possesses intrinsic

value as it is, and its transformation is desecration. Sax Russell, the physicist, embodies the Green: the planet should be made habitable. Between them, Hiroko Ai founds *areophany*, a deliberately constructed religion of the planet whose principle is *viriditas*, the greening force, which is to say a Missionaria Protectiva of terraforming. Robinson's metanational corporations, sovereign-commercial hybrids that absorb nation-states, are CHOAM's descendants.

Dune anticipates Robinson's dialectic and resolves it otherwise. Kynes is the Green; the Fremen dream of open water is areophany; and Leto II, preserving the Sareer as a desert reserve on a greened Arrakis and becoming the worm, is the Red, not by argument but by incarnation. Robinson resolves the opposition through negotiation, compromise, and the slow drafting of a Martian constitution; Herbert resolves it through a sovereign who embodies the wilderness in his own flesh. The comparison exposes both the boldness and the danger of Herbert's solution: the preservation of wildness by a single will.

8.3

The Unknowable Planet: Lem

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) presents a planetary ocean that may be a single mind, which has defeated generations of "Solaristics" and which answers the scientists orbiting it by materializing figures from their memories. Lem's novel is an epistemological tragedy: the planet cannot be understood in human terms, and the attempt to understand it reveals only the limits and the guilt of the understander. The sandworm of Arrakis is equally a mystery; the Fremen call it Shai-Hulud, Old Man of the Desert, and worship it. But Herbert's trajectory runs opposite to Lem's. Where Lem insists on the impossibility of contact, Herbert pursues contact to the point of fusion. If Kelvin, at the close of *Solaris*, waits upon the shore of an ocean he cannot comprehend, Leto enters the ocean of sand and becomes it. The contrast frames the series' ambition: not to know the planet but to become the planet's mind.

8.4

The Monastery and the Bomb: Miller

Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) traces the cycle of civilization across many centuries after a nuclear war. Monks of the Albertian Order of Leibowitz preserve the Memorabilia of the lost scientific age through a new dark age; a renaissance rediscovers science; the new civilization rebuilds its weapons and destroys itself again; and as the bombs fall, a starship carries monks and children away from Earth. The Bene Gesserit are Miller's monks transposed, an order preserving the memory of the species across catastrophe, and Miller's cyclical history is the pattern Leto II seeks to break. The difference lies in the conception of escape. Miller's starship carries the Church and its hope into the stars, a remnant faithful to a transcendent order; Leto's Scattering disperses the species in order to destroy the conditions of any single order.

8.5

Minds without Jihad: Banks

Iain M. Banks's Culture novels, beginning with *Consider Phlebas* (1987), imagine a post-scarcity civilization stewarded by benevolent artificial Minds of immense capacity, under whom humans enjoy unprecedented freedom; the Culture's covert agency, Special Circumstances, intervenes in less advanced societies by methods resembling the Bene Gesserit's. The Culture is the counterfactual of the Butlerian Jihad: a civilization in which the thinking machines won and proved benign. Banks registers the Butlerian objection in Horza, the protagonist of *Consider Phlebas*, a shape-changer who fights against the Culture because he refuses a civilization in which machines make the decisions. The dialectic between Herbert and Banks turns on the delegation of judgment. Herbert holds that judgment delegated, whether to machines, to prophets, or to priests, atrophies in the delegator; Banks holds that the Minds' self-restraint preserves human agency. Yet Banks's own subsequent novels (*The Player of Games*, 1988; *Use of Weapons*, 1990) expose the manipulations through which the Culture's benevolence operates, and in doing so return to Herbert's ground. The question is not whether the guardians are good but whether a guarded humanity can remain unforeseen.

8.6

The Core and the Shrike: Simmons

Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989) and *The Fall of Hyperion* (1990) supply the image Herbert withheld. The TechnoCore, a civilization of artificial intelligences ostensibly allied with humanity, is revealed to be exploiting the human minds linked to its farcaster network and datasphere as substrate for its own computation in pursuit of an Ultimate Intelligence; humanity is the Core's unwitting hardware. This is precisely the nightmare against which the Butlerian Jihad was fought in Herbert's schematic prehistory, and Simmons's resolution resembles Herbert's: the destruction of the farcaster network scatters humanity and severs the Core from its human substrate. Simmons and Herbert agree that the remedy for machine dominion is not counter-dominion but dispersal.

8.7

Herbert against Herbert

Herbert's own oeuvre constitutes a field in which *Dune*'s problems are tested under altered conditions. *The Santaroga Barrier* (1968) depicts a California valley whose inhabitants, sharing the consciousness-expanding substance called Jaspers, form a collective immune (the "barrier" of the title) to the market society around them; the novel remains ambivalent whether the collective is a utopia or a hive. *Hellstrom's Hive* (1973) imagines a human society reorganized on the model of the social insects. *Destination: Void* (1966) and its sequels examine the engineering of artificial

consciousness and its apotheosis. Most revealing is the ConSentiency sequence, *Whipping Star* (1970) and *The Dosadi Experiment* (1977), whose hero, Jorj X. McKie, serves the Bureau of Sabotage, an agency created after an era of ruinously efficient government in order to slow government down. BuSab is the purest expression of Herbert's political philosophy. Liberty lives in friction, delay, and inefficiency; an efficient state, like a perfect prophecy, forecloses the interval in which free beings choose. Here lies the hinge between Herbert's politics and the chronoecological thesis: freedom, for Herbert, is a property of time, specifically of the time that remains undetermined.

III

PART III

Thinking Like a Desert

Toward a Chronoecology of Sovereignty

Parts I and II have assembled the materials: the time-binding animal and its bondage; the human defined by its capacity to wait; the Khaldunian cycle; Weber's routinized charisma; the ecology of consequence; the megamachine of flesh; the breeding of the superman; and a comparative field in which prediction, messianism, and the delegation of mind recur as the constitutive problems of speculative fiction. Part III constructs from them a single framework. Its premise is that the future is a resource with an ecology: it can be extracted, depleted, protected, and restored. Its claim is that the Dune series is the most comprehensive literary investigation of that ecology yet undertaken.

CHAPTER 9

The Commons of the Future

Prescient Extraction and Temporal Desertification

9.1 Melange: Futurity in Solid Form

Every property of melange is a relation to time. It prolongs life, retarding the body's passage toward death. It induces addiction, which the glossary grades from mild in small quantities to severe above two grams daily per seventy kilos of body weight, binding the user's future to an uninterrupted supply; Jessica understands, as the spice settles into her body, that no Bene Gesserit artifice can now pry her and her son free of Arrakis (Book I). It saturates the eyes of long-term users with the blue-within-blue of the Ibad, the visible sign of a body colonized by its substance. And it confers prescience: in Guild navigators it permits the perception of safe paths through space, in the Bene Gesserit it opens Other Memory, and in Paul it opens the future. The Imperium's interstellar unity depends upon a drug of foresight. Melange is, in the most exact sense available, futurity in solid form: the future materialized as a commodity that can be mined, stockpiled, taxed, smuggled, and monopolized.

Marx's analysis of the commodity in the first volume of *Das Kapital* (1867) begins from the observation that a commodity, apparently trivial, proves on analysis to abound in metaphysical subtleties: its exchange-value, a social relation, appears as a natural property of a thing. Melange is the commodity whose fetish is real. It does not merely appear to possess supernatural powers; it possesses them. Herbert has constructed an economy in which the mystification Marx diagnosed becomes literal truth, and in so doing has made visible an insight Marx's framework could only imply: that the deepest commodity of any civilization is the security of its future.

9.2 Prescient Extraction

I define *prescient extraction* as the process by which an agent converts the open field of possible futures into determinate certainty and appropriates the resulting predictability as power. *Dune* and its sequels identify at least four mechanisms.

The first is *Heisenbergian fixation*. Herbert describes Paul's prescience as subject to a kind of Heisenberg indeterminacy: the expenditure of energy required to reveal the future alters what is

revealed. To see is to intervene; the observed future is a future modified by observation and, in the limit, a future fixed by it. The more clearly Paul sees, the narrower the field becomes.

The second is the *self-fulfilling prophecy*, which Robert K. Merton defined (1948) as a false definition of a situation that evokes behavior which makes the originally false conception come true. The Missionaria Protectiva manufactures self-fulfilling prophecies at industrial scale. The Fremen believe that an off-world mother and son will come; when Jessica and Paul arrive, the belief generates the behavior (acceptance, devotion, war) that makes them the prophesied ones. The prophecy produces its fulfiller.

The third is the *oracle's trap*, the central device of *Dune Messiah*. The conspirators (the Reverend Mother Mohiam, the Guild Steersman Edric, the Tleilaxu Face Dancer Scytale, and the Princess Irulan) understand that a prescient emperor can be attacked through his prescience. Edric's own prescient presence clouds Paul's vision, since one oracle masks another; the Tarot of Dune, disseminated throughout the Imperium, muddies prescience; and the plot is so constructed that every foreseen path conducts Paul toward the outcome the conspirators desire. The prescient is captured by his own map.

The fourth is *optimization*, the Guild's practice of choosing always the safe path. Paul perceives in *Dune* that the navigators, seeing the future, invariably select the course of least risk, and that this habit has led them, and the civilization that depends on them, into stagnation. Prescience in the service of safety becomes the systematic elimination of variance, and variance is what a species requires in order to adapt. Paul's final diagnosis of the Guild is couched in the vocabulary of ecology. The navigators erred by specializing on the melange narcotic; rather than seize Arrakis when they grasped their dependence, they lived from moment to moment, like parasites hoping that the sea in which they swam would produce a new host when the old one died, and chose always "the clear, safe course" that leads downward into stagnation (Book III). Specialization, parasitism, and stagnation are the terms of an ecologist, not of a strategist.

The homology with the political economy of prediction in the early twenty-first century is structural rather than allegorical. Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) describes an economic order that extracts "behavioral surplus" from human experience, fabricates it into "prediction products," and trades them in "behavioral futures markets," and that in its mature form seeks not merely to predict behavior but to modify it so that predictions come true, a regime she names instrumentarian power. The spice economy is a behavioral futures market in the literal sense, and the Missionaria Protectiva is an instrumentarian power that has learned to manufacture the behavior it forecasts. Herbert's insight, available in 1965 and seldom articulated in his reception, is that prediction is a mode of production: the forecaster manufactures the forecast.

9.3

From Time-Binding to Time-Bondage

Chapter 1 traced Korzybski's definition of humanity as the time-binding class of life. In the Dune series, time-binding is pressed to totality in both directions. Other Memory binds the entire past into the present consciousness of the adept; prescience binds the future. The present becomes a narrow defile between two total archives, one of ancestors and one of outcomes, and the living person becomes a host: to the dead, as in Alia, or to the foreseen, as in Paul. The Bene Gesserit name for the pathology at the scale of the individual is Abomination. This dissertation proposes a name for its civilizational form.

9.4

Temporal Desertification

I define *temporal desertification* as the depletion, through excessive prediction, control, and stabilization, of a civilization's capacity to generate and absorb novelty. The term borrows the logic of its ecological namesake: a desert is produced not by the absence of resources but by their mismanagement, through overgrazing, deforestation, and the destruction of the systems that retain water and soil. Temporal desertification is produced by the overgrazing of the future.

The Imperium of *Dune* is the paradigmatic temporally desertified civilization. Its political order has endured for ten thousand years with little structural change. Its class system, the faufreluches, assigns every person a fixed place. Its Great Convention regulates warfare among the houses so that none can decisively defeat another. Its Guild, navigating by foresight, chooses always the safe path. Its Bene Gesserit pursue a breeding program older than most civilizations. Its technological innovation is confined to the margins, to Ix and Tleilax. Every major institution of the Imperium is designed to prevent surprise. Even prediction is domesticated: the Imperium licenses foresight only as navigation, truthsaying, and computation, and its term of scorn for the Umma, the brotherhood of prophets, designates any "wild" person given to fanatical prediction (Terminology). The jihad is what follows when prediction escapes its license. The result is a civilization of extraordinary stability and extraordinary fragility: having eliminated the small variances through which complex systems adapt, it lies exposed to a single large one.

The ecological analogy that best captures the dynamic is fire suppression. Twentieth-century forest management in the United States suppressed wildfire as a matter of policy; the suppression allowed fuel to accumulate on the forest floor, so that when fire came at last it came as catastrophe. Paul's jihad is the catastrophic wildfire of a civilization that suppressed its small fires for ten millennia. Herbert gives the dynamic an explicit biological interpretation: in *Dune*, Paul perceives the jihad as the expression of the species' terrible purpose, a race consciousness that, sensing genetic stagnation, drives toward the mixing of its bloodlines through war. The Bene Gesserit name the condition before Paul does. Early in Book I, the Reverend Mother tells Jessica that the race knows its own mortality and fears the stagnation of its heredity, an urge in the bloodstream

to mingle genetic strains without plan, beside which the Imperium, CHOAM, and the Great Houses are so much flotsam. In the stilltent at the end of Book I, Paul sees every party, Sisterhood, Emperor, and Harkonnens alike, caught in the race's need to renew its *scattered* inheritance by crossing and mingling. The word that will name Leto's solution is already on the page. The jihad is an involuntary rewilding, the burning of an overgrown future.

Garrett Hardin's "The Tragedy of the Commons" (1968), published as Herbert was completing the first sequel, supplies the economic model. When a resource is held in common and each user acts rationally to maximize his own gain, the aggregate result is the ruin of the resource. The future is the ultimate commons, and prescience is the instrument by which individual actors maximize their own security: the Guild seeks safe paths, the Bene Gesserit a controllable Kwisatz Haderach, the Emperor the elimination of threats to his throne, the great houses the perpetuation of their dynasties. Each acts rationally; the aggregate is the exhaustion of novelty. Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons* (1990) demonstrated that commons need not end in tragedy where communities develop institutions of collective governance, and the Fremen sietch is an Ostromian institution: water is held in common, its use governed by strict rules and graduated sanctions, the water of the dead returned to the tribe. The Fremen are corrupted precisely when abundance breaks the water commons open. The question the Golden Path answers is whether the commons of the future can be governed at all, and, if not by a community, by whom.

9.5

The Pharmacology of Prescience

Jacques Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) reads the myth in Plato's *Phaedrus* in which the god Theuth presents writing to King Thamus as a remedy for memory, and Thamus replies that writing will instead produce forgetfulness, since those who rely upon it will cease to exercise recollection. Derrida shows that the Greek *pharmakon* signifies both remedy and poison, and that Plato's text cannot stabilize the distinction. Bernard Stiegler extended the argument into a general pharmacology of technics (*La technique et le temps*, 1994–2001; *Ce qui fait que la vie vaut la peine d'être vécue*, 2010): every technical supplement to human capacity is a pharmakon, at once enabling and toxic, and the question is never whether to use it but how to care for its dosage.

The Dune series is the most sustained literary exploration of pharmacology in this sense. Melange is the master pharmakon: life-extending and enslaving, enabling and addictive, and lethal in its raw eruption, the spice blow that kills Liet-Kynes. The Water of Life is a poison that becomes, through the Reverend Mother's metabolic transmutation, the sacrament of communion. The gom jabbar is a poison that tests for humanity. Prescience is a remedy for uncertainty that poisons the future. Other Memory inverts Thamus's complaint: where writing externalized memory and weakened it, Other Memory internalizes all memory and overwhelms the rememberer. Derrida's analysis also discloses a second term, the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from

the city to purify it. Paul ends *Dune Messiah* blinded, walking into the desert as the Fremen abandon their blind, at once Oedipus who knew too much and Tiresias the blind seer, and returns in *Children of Dune* as the Preacher, an outcast denouncing the religion founded in his name. The messiah becomes the scapegoat. Prescience, in Herbert's pharmacology, is a drug whose overdose is history itself.

CHAPTER 10

Immunitas

The Immunitary Architectures of the Imperium

10.1 The Paradigm

Roberto Esposito's *Immunitas* (2002) and *Bios* (2004) reconstruct modern political thought around a pair of terms derived from the Latin *munus*: a gift that obligates, an office, a duty. *Communitas* is the condition of those bound by a shared *munus*, an obligation of reciprocal giving that exposes each member to the others. *Immunitas* is exemption from that obligation; the immune person is the one dispensed from the *munus*. Esposito argues that modernity is organized by an immunitary paradigm in which political institutions protect life by negating it in controlled doses, on the model of vaccination, the introduction of an attenuated pathogen to provoke a protective response, and that this paradigm tends toward autoimmunity, the condition in which the protective apparatus turns against the life it protects. Derrida's late writings (*Foi et savoir*, 1996; *Voyous*, 2003) developed a parallel concept of autoimmunity as the self-destructive logic of every institution that defends itself.

The novel's own lexicon licenses this reading. The glossary defines the Missionaria Protectiva as the arm of the Sisterhood charged with "sowing infectious superstitions" on primitive worlds, and glosses the Fremen idiom "dark things" as the infectious superstitions it teaches to "susceptible" civilizations (Terminology). Paul, rising from the gom jabbar, feels himself "infected with terrible purpose" (Book I), and later sees himself infected by the wild race consciousness that is moving the human universe toward chaos (Book II); of the Guild, as Chapter 9 showed, he concludes that it lived as a parasite awaiting a new host (Book III). Contagion, susceptibility, and parasitism are not metaphors imported by the interpreter. They are the novel's own terms.

The immunitary paradigm is the operating system of Herbert's universe. Every major institution of the series can be described as an immunitary device, and every catastrophe as autoimmune. The sections that follow trace the paradigm across five scales: body, psyche, species, polity, and cognition.

10.2

The Body: The Stillsuit

The Fremen stillsuit recovers the water of perspiration and bodily waste, purifies it, and returns it to the wearer through a catchpocket tube. It is an immune membrane against the planet, the body sealed against a desert that would otherwise draw every molecule of moisture from it. In Peter Sloterdijk's terms (*Sphären*, 1998–2004), the stillsuit is a wearable sphere, a portable microclimate that encloses life in an artificial atmosphere. Yet the stillsuit is embedded in an economy that is also communal. The sietch collects the water of the dead and renders it to the tribe; water debts bind members to one another; the gift of water is the highest form of obligation. The Fremen water economy is simultaneously *immunitas* (individual sealing) and *communitas* (shared obligation), and its genius lies in their articulation. The scene in which Paul, having killed Jamis in the ritual duel, weeps at the funeral, and the Fremen receive his tears with awe as a gift of moisture to the dead, is the novel's most exact representation of the *munus*: the scandalous gift that binds the giver to the community. Paul enters the communitas of the Fremen through an act of unimmunized expenditure, and the cry that runs around the ring, that Usul gives moisture to the dead (Book II), names the gift exactly. The messianic title belongs to the same economy: the glossary records that Lisan al-Gaib is sometimes translated "Giver of Water." Before he is anything else, the Fremen messiah is defined by the *munus*.

10.3

The Psyche: The Litany

The Litany Against Fear is a psychic immunization. It does not eliminate fear; it admits fear, permits it to pass through the self, and observes its passage. Its modern clinical analogue is graduated exposure, the core technique of behavior therapy since Joseph Wolpe's *Psychotherapy by Reciprocal Inhibition* (1958), in which the patient is exposed to the feared stimulus in controlled doses until the response is extinguished. The Bene Gesserit train by exactly this method, and the gom jabbar is its final examination: a lethal threat and an unbearable pain administered together, to be endured without flight.

10.4

The Species: The Water of Life

The Water of Life is the paradigm of immunization in the series. It is obtained by drowning a small sandworm, whose exhalation is a poison lethal to nearly all who drink it. The Reverend Mother candidate survives by transmuting the poison within her own body, altering its molecular structure through conscious mastery of her biochemistry; the transmuted water then becomes a catalyst that, distributed to the sietch, induces a shared ecstatic communion, the *tau*. The individual body is the laboratory in which the community's poison becomes its sacrament. Paul's

survival of the Water of Life, an ordeal that has killed every man who attempted it, is the proof of his status as Kwisatz Haderach. Alia's pre-birth, the consequence of Jessica's drinking while pregnant, is the series' first autoimmune event: the transmutation reaches the fetus, which awakens to Other Memory before it possesses a self to defend.

10.5

The Polity: The Shield and the Great Convention

The Holtzman shield, which protects persons and structures by repelling objects moving above a threshold velocity, is the master image of the Imperium's temporality. It is a selectively permeable membrane: it blocks the fast and admits the slow. A slow blade can penetrate it, and Imperial combat has accordingly regressed to swordsmanship and the knife, to a feudal martial culture of feints and slow thrusts. The lasgun, which might otherwise dominate, is neutralized by the shield's own immunology, since a lasgun beam striking a shield produces a reaction comparable to an atomic detonation that destroys shooter and target alike; the two technologies deter each other. The Great Convention's prohibition of atomics against human beings completes the system, and the Convention is formalist to its core: each of its rules, the glossary notes, begins with the injunction that the forms must be obeyed (Terminology). Paul exploits the form against its purpose. Because the Convention's language forbids atomics against humans, he turns the Atreides family atomics on the Shield Wall, a rampart of rock rather than a population; and when Gurney objects that the point is too fine, Paul answers that fear, not the injunction, keeps the Houses from using atomics on one another (Book III). The law is deterrence's alibi. The Imperium is a shielded body through which only slow motions pass.

Herbert's politics, as BuSab shows, value slowness as the medium of freedom. The Imperium values slowness as the medium of stasis. The distinction between these two slownesses, the friction that preserves choice and the inertia that preserves order, is the axis on which the series' political judgments turn, and it reappears in the analysis of Leto's reign.

10.6

Cognition: The Butlerian Jihad

The Butlerian Jihad was a species-scale immune response against an invasive form of cognition. Its commandment functions as antigen recognition, identifying the likeness of a human mind as the marker of the pathogen. The Mentats, navigators, and Bene Gesserit who filled the cognitive niche vacated by the machines are, in this framework, antibodies: human tissues differentiated to perform the functions the pathogen once performed. The outcome is autoimmune in Mumford's sense (Chapter 5): the protective response converted the protected body into the thing it feared. Leto II's diagnosis, that the Jihad's true target was a machine-attitude, identifies the precise failure, and the first novel already documents it. Appendix II describes the Imperium's agnostic ruling class, the Guild included, as treating religion as a puppet show to keep the populace

docile and as believing that all phenomena, religious ones included, can be reduced to mechanical explanations. The immune response destroyed the instruments and spared the attitude, which then colonized human flesh.

10.7

Belief: The Missionaria Protectiva

The Missionaria Protectiva is a vaccination program of belief. Its agents introduce into primitive cultures an attenuated messianism (legends of a coming mother and son, of a voice from the outer world, of a Reverend Mother to be recognized by certain signs), so that a Bene Gesserit who later finds herself in danger among those cultures can activate the belief for her protection. Jessica's and Paul's survival among the Fremen depends on precisely this prophylaxis; Jessica recognizes the signs and plays the role the legend has prepared. The autoimmune reversal follows. The vaccine becomes the virus: the planted messianism, once activated, does not merely protect the Bene Gesserit agent but produces a messiah beyond the order's control and a jihad that consumes the Imperium.

10.8

The Autoimmune Imperium

The catalogue of autoimmune reversals in the series is comprehensive. The breeding program, designed to produce a controllable superman, produces an uncontrollable one. The prophylactic myth produces the catastrophe it was meant to forestall. The Butlerian prohibition of thinking machines produces human machines. The Guild's prescience, employed to secure safe paths, blinds the Guild to the one path that matters. The ecological transformation of Arrakis, designed to liberate the Fremen, threatens the worm on which their world and the Imperium depend; Appendix I already records the sand plankton poisoned at the margin of the plantings. Other Memory, designed to enrich the adept, produces Abomination. And the Emperor's own immunitary secret, the forging of the Sardaukar on the harsh prison planet of Salusa Secundus, is surpassed by Arrakis, whose harsher conditions produced the Fremen: the Emperor's method, scaled to a planet, generates the force that overthrows him. Paul grasps the homology as a boy: told of Salusa Secundus, he remarks to Hawat that it sounds much like Arrakis, if perhaps not quite as bad (Book I).

The common structure is that every immunitary device in the Imperium is aimed at the prevention of surprise. The order protects itself against variance, novelty, and the unforeseen, and the accumulated suppression of small surprises renders the eventual large surprise catastrophic. The Imperium is an immunitary civilization in permanent autoimmune crisis because its immune system attacks the very capacity for adaptation on which long-term survival depends. This is the condition Leto II inherits.

CHAPTER 11

The Keystone Sovereign

Leto II, Leviathan, and the Rewilding of Time

11.1 Refusal and Acceptance

Paul saw the Golden Path and refused it. Its price was the transformation of his body and the forfeiture of his humanity, and Paul, who had already surrendered much of his humanity to the jihad, declined to pay. His son pays. In *Children of Dune*, Leto II, a preborn child who has mastered the inner multitude that destroyed his aunt, walks into the deep desert, covers his body with a living membrane of sandtrout, and begins a metamorphosis that will make him, over thirty-five centuries, a sandworm with a human face. Father and son meet in the desert, two prescients, one who refused and one who accepts; Paul, now the blind Preacher denouncing the religion of Muad'Dib, recognizes that his son has chosen what he could not.

The difference between them is not courage but their relation to the future. Paul's prescience showed him futures to avoid, and every avoidance led to a worse one; his relation to the future was defensive. Leto's prescience shows him the single future in which humanity survives the extinction toward which all other paths converge, and his relation to the future is constructive: he accepts the Golden Path as a project. The project, however, has an unusual structure. Its goal is a future that Leto himself cannot see.

11.2 Thinking Like a Desert

Chapter 4 introduced Leopold's parable of the wolf and the mountain. Its application to Leto's reign can now be specified. A keystone species, in the ecological sense established by Robert T. Paine's experiments on intertidal predators (1966; named in 1969), is one whose effect on its ecosystem is disproportionate to its abundance: remove it, and the system reorganizes or collapses. The sandworm is Arrakis's keystone, and the greening of the planet threatens it. Leto's response is to become the keystone. He preserves the Sareer, the last region of true desert, as a wilderness reserve; he carries the sandtrout in his own body, the future of the worms awaiting his death; and he positions himself as the apex predator of the human ecology, the single presence around which every other power (the Bene Gesserit, Ix, the Tleilaxu, the Guild, the Fish Speakers) must organize its behavior.

Leopold's wolf, by preying upon deer, maintains the mountain's vegetation; Leto, by preying upon the civilization he governs, maintains the human future's capacity for regeneration. His tyranny culls ambition, suppresses accumulation, and prevents any rival power from monopolizing the future. To think like a desert, in this dissertation's sense, is to evaluate action on the timescale of the desert, in millennia rather than in lifetimes, and to measure the health of a system not by its productivity or its predictability but by its capacity to generate surprise. Leto thinks like a desert. He is the only figure in the series who does.

11.3

The Last Leviathan

Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) named the sovereign commonwealth after the sea monster of the Book of Job, the creature against which no earthly power prevails, and called it a "mortal god" under the immortal God. Its justification is escape from the state of nature, the war of every man against every man, in which human life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short." Leto II is the Leviathan rendered literal: a monstrous creature of the deep sand, the incarnation of Shai-Hulud, a mortal god whose subjects worship him. His reign is a Hobbesian peace. For three and a half millennia there is no war of consequence among the great powers, because no power can contest his.

The telos of Leto's Leviathan, however, inverts Hobbes's. The Hobbesian sovereign secures peace in order to preserve the lives of his subjects within a stable order; Leto secures peace in order to produce, at his death, an explosion of dispersal that will place humanity beyond the reach of any future Leviathan. His reign is designed to terminate the conditions of sovereignty itself. Carl Schmitt's theology of history (*Der Nomos der Erde*, 1950) supplies the term that captures this function: the *katechon*, the restrainer of the Second Letter to the Thessalonians, who holds back the advent of the Antichrist and so defers the end. Leto is a katechon who restrains not the end of the world but the end of the species, the extinction that every path other than the Golden Path produces, and who does so by restraining history itself for thirty-five centuries.

11.4

The Inoculating Tyrant

In Esposito's terms, Leto's reign is a vaccination of the species against the messianic. He administers to humanity a controlled dose, though thirty-five centuries is a dose of unprecedented magnitude, of the thing it must learn to resist: absolute rule by a prescient god. Leto conceives his purpose as a lesson to be learned not by humanity's understanding but in its bones. He hoards the spice, restricts travel, suppresses rival institutions, enforces his peace through the Fish Speakers, an army of women who put down dissent with lethal force, and directs the matings of the Atreides line across generations. The pressure accumulates. At his death the Famine Times and

the Scattering follow, and humanity disperses into the universe in numbers and directions that no single power can track.

The forestry analogy introduced in Chapter 9 can now be completed. If the jihad was the catastrophic wildfire of a civilization that had suppressed its fires for ten millennia, the Golden Path is a prescribed burn: a deliberate, governed fire set to consume accumulated fuel and restore the regenerative capacity of the system. The difference between the jihad and the Golden Path is the difference between an involuntary and a deliberate rewilding.

11.5

Siona and the Right to Be Unforeseen

The culmination of the Golden Path is Siona Atreides, daughter of Leto's majordomo Moneo and product of the thirty-five-century breeding program. Siona's defining trait is invisibility to prescience, and her descendants will carry it, so that no future oracle, however powerful, can capture the whole of the human future. In parallel, Leto permits and encourages the Ixians to develop the no-ship, a vessel invisible to prescient search. The two developments, biological and technological, converge on a single end: the restoration of unpredictability to the human species.

The first novel had already planted both exceptions. Paul's leverage over the Guild at the climax is his own invisibility: the finest navigators, questing ahead through time for the safest courses, are searching for him and cannot find him (Book III). And in the Emperor's presence, Paul realizes why Count Hasimir Fenring has never appeared anywhere in his visions. Fenring is one of the "might-have-beens," an almost-Kwisatz Haderach crippled by a flaw in the genetic pattern, his talent turned inward to furtiveness and seclusion (Book III). *Dune* thus contains, in Fenring, a product of the breeding program invisible to prescience, and in Paul a prescient invisible to other prescients. Siona generalizes the exception into an inheritance.

I call this *temporal rewilding*. In ecological practice, rewilding restores self-regulating ecosystems by reintroducing keystone species and withdrawing human management, accepting that the restored system will behave in ways no manager can foresee. Temporal rewilding restores the future's capacity to surprise by reintroducing unpredictability into the species and dismantling the apparatus of prescient management. Leto's paradox is that this rewilding must be administered by the greatest manager in human history; his solution is to make his management culminate in its own impossibility.

The rewilded future is not benign. In *Heretics of Dune* and *Chapterhouse: Dune*, the Scattering returns its predators: the Honored Matres, a violent order of women formed in the unknown territories of the dispersal, and behind them an unnamed enemy that drives them. Wild futures contain wolves. Herbert's ethic is not utopian; it does not promise that a rewilded future will be good, only that it will be open. The right Leto secures for humanity is not the right to happiness but the right to be unforeseen.

11.6

Messianism against Messianism

Walter Benjamin's "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940) attributes to every generation a weak messianic power, a capacity to redeem the past by interrupting the continuum of history. Giorgio Agamben's *Il tempo che resta* (2000), reading the letters of the apostle Paul, describes messianic time as the time that remains, the operational time in which the present contracts toward its end. The Dune series, in whose first novel a man named Paul founds a religion, completes its arc with a messianism directed against messianism. The Golden Path disperses messianic power: after Siona, no single prescient can capture the future, and each unforeseeable human bears a weak messianic power that no oracle can read. The Herbertian paradox with which this dissertation began is thereby resolved. Herbert critiqued the hero by perfecting the heroic narrative because the only defensible messiah is the one who abolishes the conditions of messianism: who rules in order to end rule, foresees in order to end foresight, and dies in order that no successor can arise.

11.7

Objections

Four objections require answer.

The first is that this reading constitutes an apology for tyranny. Leto's justification is unfalsifiable, since only he sees the Golden Path, and his journals, the principal source for his reign, are self-serving. Herbert does not resolve the ambiguity, and this dissertation does not claim that the novels endorse Leto's rule as policy. The claim is structural: if the future is a commons depleted by prediction, its restoration cannot be accomplished by a predictor without contradiction. Leto embodies that contradiction and dies of it. His death, plotted by Siona and Duncan Idaho and accomplished when his cart falls from the bridge into the Idaho River, is the contradiction's resolution.

The second is that Leto repeats the eugenic logic he opposes. He does; the anti-eugenic telos of his breeding program does not redeem its method. Herbert's irony here is incomplete, and the series' persistent fascination with breeders marks a limit of its political imagination that Octavia E. Butler's work exposes.

The third concerns gender. Leto's army of Fish Speakers rests on his conviction that women are less prone than men to certain forms of violence, and the Bene Gesserit's power is organized around the female reproductive body. Feminist criticism (Kennedy 2020) has documented both the series' unusual centering of female institutional power and its reliance on essentialized sexual difference. The chronoecological reading inherits these tensions without resolving them.

The fourth is logical: does Leto foresee the success of the Golden Path? If he does, Siona is not truly invisible; if he does not, his reign rests upon faith. The second answer is correct, and it is the key to the whole. Leto's final act is a leap beyond prescience in Kierkegaard's sense (*Frygt og*

Bæven, 1843), a teleological suspension of the ethical undertaken for an end he cannot see. The being who saw every other future stakes everything on the one future he cannot see. In that act the Golden Path discloses its ultimate meaning: foresight serves, at its highest, the creation of what cannot be foreseen.

CONCLUSION

Dune After Prediction

C.1 Contributions

This dissertation has advanced three contributions. Genealogically, it has reconstructed the intellectual sources of *Dune* as a coherent pattern rather than a catalogue: each source (Korzybski's time-binding, Jung's inflation, Jaspers's limit situation, Heidegger's anticipation, Ibn Khaldun's cycle, Weber's routinization, Leopold's mountain, Butler's machines, Mumford's megamachine, Plato's guardians, Nietzsche's recurrence) was recruited for its bearing on the problem of how a finite organism can bind time without being bound by it. Morphologically, it has situated *Dune* within the major works of speculative and philosophical fiction as the field's most comprehensive dissent from the twin temptations of prediction (Asimov's psychohistory, Chiang's Predictor, Liu's sophons) and of collective transcendence (Asimov's Galaxia, Clarke's Overmind), and as its most rigorous meditation on the delegation of judgment (Banks, Simmons). Conceptually, it has proposed a chronoecological framework comprising four concepts, prescient extraction, temporal desertification, immunitary sovereignty, and temporal rewilding, together with an ethical-epistemic disposition, thinking like a desert, that evaluates regimes of knowledge and power by the capacity for surprise they conserve.

C.2 Beyond Herbert

The framework's reach extends beyond the Dune series. The phrase "Butlerian Jihad" has become a recurrent reference in public discussion of artificial intelligence, typically as shorthand for a prohibitionist response to machine cognition. The reading developed here suggests that this usage misreads Herbert. The Jihad, in the novels, is not a solution but an autoimmune event, and Herbert's concern is not machines as such but any apparatus, mechanical, biological, institutional, or religious, that converts open futures into managed certainty and invites the delegation of judgment. The chronoecological question to put to any predictive technology is therefore not whether it is mechanical or human but whether it conserves or depletes the future's capacity for surprise, and whether those it predicts retain the right to be unforeseen.

The framework bears equally on the environmental humanities. Climate science is a discipline of foresight, and its projections are indispensable. Chronoecology does not oppose foresight; it

distinguishes foresight that conserves possibility (Leopold's thinking like a mountain, or the planetologist at his best, whose forecast Appendix I calls an "open-end prediction") from prescience that consumes it. The former keeps the future open by understanding consequences; the latter closes it by fixing outcomes. Herbert's planetologists and prophets are alike foresighted; what divides them is whether their foresight serves a system's capacity for renewal or its subjection to a plan.

C.3

Reception as Routinization

The posthumous history of *Dune* enacts the process the novels analyze. Since Herbert's death in 1986, the franchise has been extended by prequels and sequels composed by Brian Herbert and Kevin J. Anderson, by games, and by films. In Weber's terms, the charisma of the founding work has been routinized into an institution that preserves its legitimating force while transforming its content. The film adaptations dramatize the stakes. David Lynch's *Dune* (1984) ends with rain falling on Arrakis, a miracle that confirms Paul's divinity and literalizes the messianic fulfillment the novel withholds. Denis Villeneuve's *Dune: Part Two* (2024) restores the critique by making Chani a skeptic of the prophecy, so that its final movement is not a miracle but a refusal. Each adaptation decides anew whether to tell the story the paratexts warn against.

C.4

Limitations and Further Research

This study has worked from the published texts and Herbert's published nonfiction. Archival research in Herbert's papers at California State University, Fullerton, would permit the attested and probable sources distinguished here to be tested against Herbert's notes and correspondence. The chronoecological framework invites application to other bodies of work (Le Guin's Hainish cycle, Robinson's climate fiction, Butler's Earthseed novels) and to political theory, where the right to be unforeseen might be developed as a principle for the governance of predictive systems. Finally, the postcolonial dimension of the framework, colonialism as the appropriation of another people's future, warrants fuller development in dialogue with historians of Islam and of the Caucasus, whose expertise can restore the specific traditions from which Herbert borrowed to their own histories and their own futures.

C.5

Coda

The Fremen hold their water in common, guard it against every unguarded loss, and spend it only under discipline, because they know that on Arrakis the reserve is life and its waste is death. The future, Herbert's novels suggest, is held in the same way. Every prediction spends some of it;

every certainty secured draws down the reserve of the unforeseen from which a species renews itself. To think like a desert is to understand that the future is the deepest commons, that it is lost through every pore of a civilization that seeks to know it too completely, and that it is preserved only by disciplines that refuse to spend it all at once. Leto II spent thirty-five centuries learning this, and died so that the reserve might be refilled. That the lesson is delivered by a tyrant, and that it cannot be verified, is not its flaw but its form: the open future can be defended only by those who will not live to see it.

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KEYWORDS

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